Module Two

Genesis & the Pentateuch

Knowing God's Story & Leading by Faith

Manual for Trainers

February 2023

"Know therefore that the LORD your God is God; he is the faithful God, keeping his covenant of love to a thousand generations of those who love him and keep his commandments."

Deuteronomy 7:9

Introducing BUILD

'Building leaders, building churches, building the kingdom'

Most church leaders in the world today serve the growing churches of the majority world. It is impossible to overstate the significance of these local leaders for the current health and future prospects of the worldwide church, but most have received little or no training. In response, BUILD equips leaders to grow healthy churches. It does so with confidence because Jesus made a promise: "I will build my church" (Matthew 16:18).

BUILD stands for 'Biblical Understanding for In-service Leadership Development' and grew out of the Church of Uganda's (COU) response to its training needs. BUILD is first and foremost a grassroots church leadership training initiative, but it is implemented locally as a training programme. BUILD has its own course and materials, designed and developed in Uganda, which help deliver biblical, theological and practical education. It does so by training trainers to use its curriculum, which also forms the basis for an academic programme for some trainers.

This multiplication model means BUILD can have an extensive impact. This has been recognised and BUILD is used by other churches in similar contexts, particularly but not exclusively in East Africa. A regional BUILD network exists as a result.

The compiling of the BUILD curriculum has primarily been the work of Canon Dr Jem Hovil with Canon Stephen Ssenyonjo Kewaza. But due to the nature of the design and development process the materials capture the input and perspectives of many individuals. The bulk of the work was carried out through ten participatory curriculum development workshops hosted by Uganda Martyrs Seminary, Namugongo from 2009 to 2014. Those brought together participants from Uganda, South Sudan, Rwanda, Tanzania and Kenya, while others from Burundi and Congo contributed later. The workshops were based on earlier research that included 573 survey responses. That lengthy list of voices is representative of the many at the grassroots who continue to use the materials and provide feedback.

Special mention also goes to Mr Daniel Mukiibi Muwanguzi in Uganda who was instrumental in shaping the training there, and seeing it through the accreditation process. Canon Capt Benjamin Kibara Wathituni was key to a similar process in Kenya, and critical in both the ongoing revision and translation of materials. BUILD has grown under the watchful eye of a number of COU Archbishops. These include the Most Reverend Henry Luke Orombi, the COU's seventh Archbishop, who wrote these words to commend and launch the programme:

"The COU is very grateful for the BUILD initiative, which has given us simple, practical and effective tools for equipping our multitude of workers on the ground. Many leaders need training brought to them and on-going encouragement in the midst of the challenges of serving Jesus Christ today. BUILD is meeting those needs with its faithfulness to the truth and teaching of the Bible, and is bringing change to people's lives, churches and communities. All this is in keeping with the COU's core values, such as selfless service. The COU is very proud of this home grown resource, which we have had such a hand in developing. And we now praise God for the way in which he is using BUILD to strengthen and multiply church leaders in our neighbouring countries and beyond. We trust that you will find BUILD as useful and instructive as we do, and may God continue to bless this work and build his church, to the praise and glory of his name."

To echo that, we pray that you will be built up through BUILD and go on to build up many others in their faith and in their faithfulness as leaders in God's Church.

Abbreviations

Old Testament books

Gen	Genesis	Song	Song of Songs
Exod	Exodus	lsa	Isaiah
Lev	Leviticus	Jer	Jeremiah
Num	Numbers	Lam	Lamentations
Deut	Deuteronomy	Ezek	Ezekiel
Josh	Joshua	Dan	Daniel
Judg	Judges	Hos	Hosea
Ruth	Ruth	Joel	Joel
1-2 Sam	1-2 Samuel	Amos	Amos
1-2 Kgs	1-2 Kings	Obad	Obadiah
1-2 Chr	1-2 Chronicles	Jonah	Jonah
Ezra	Ezra	Mic	Micah
Neh	Nehemiah	Nah	Nahum
Esth	Esther	Hab	Habakkuk
Job	Job	Zeph	Zephaniah
Ps/Pss	Psalms	Hag	Haggai
Prov	Proverbs	Zech	Zechariah
Eccl	Ecclesiastes	Mal	Malachi

New Testament books

Matt	Matthew	1-2 Thess	1-2 Thessalonians
Mark	Mark	1-2 Tim	1-2 Timothy
Luke	Luke	Titus	Titus
John	John	Phlm	Philemon
Acts	Acts	Heb	Hebrews
Rom	Romans	Jas	James
1-2 Cor	1-2 Corinthians	1-2 Pet	1-2 Peter
Gal	Galatians	1-2-3 John	1-2-3 John
Eph	Ephesians	Jude	Jude
Phil	Philippians	Rev	Revelation
Col	Colossians		

Other abbreviations

NT	New Testament	v. (vv.)	verse (verses)
OT	Old Testament	ch. (chs)	chapter (chapters)
		p. (pp.)	page (pages)

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Introductory notes for trainers

Who is this manual for? *The manual has been designed to help church leaders strengthen other church leaders. For example, it will help those who lead parishes with a number of local congregations and leaders within them. Or those who have wider responsibility for churches and leaders in their area. In Anglican churches that includes vicars, archdeacons and diocesan education coordinators. And Bishops should be familiar with the programme. If you want help in training others, this manual is for you.*

In what ways is this manual different to the manual for participants? *The main difference is that there are notes for Trainers in italics. These provide additional material, which will help you to use the manual. The notes have been designed to build your training skills over time and through the course of the modules. However, you will need to 'own' the manual by adding your own comments, notes, questions and insights as you prepare and use the material. Finally, because of the additional notes, the page numbers are different. The section numbers and titles remain the same however. Use those section numbers and titles to guide your participants.*

How much time should be given to each learning unit? *The learning achieved is more important than the time allotted. And units may take less time to cover as the module progresses. However, two hours per unit is a good guideline, and six hours per day a good limit if you are able to have a residential or day workshop. However, the modules and their units can be taught in a variety of different ways. For example a day a week; or a day or two a month; or through evening classes. The following timings can guide you as you discuss them with the participants:*

8.00 a.m. - 8.45 a.m.	*Devotions (including preaching practice)*
9.00 a.m. - 11.00 a.m.	*Session I (2 hours, followed by a 30 minute break)*
11.30 a.m. - 1.00 p.m.	*Session II (1½ hours, followed a 1 hour break)*
2.00 p.m. - 3.30 p.m.	*Session IIII (1½ hours, followed by a 30 minute break)*
4.00 p.m. - 5.00 p.m.	*Session IV (1 hour, followed by the evening break)*

The evening break can include time for learners to review the days' units, as well as to look ahead and prepare for the next day. It can also include recreation time.

What Bible passages can be used for the talk in the devotions? *The devotions and the preaching practice they include are an integral part of the training. Some of the following passages, which are not covered directly in the module, can be used: Exodus 1:15-22; 4:18-31; 5:22-6:12; 11:1-10; 12:31-42; 17:1-7; 18:13-27.*

How should the talk given in the devotions be evaluated? *Encourage discussion of the talk after it has been given, and after any response of prayer or worship that might follow. This must lead to the sort of feedback that will help preachers to grow in their confidence and ability. Use these three questions to guide the process:*

*(1) Was the talk **true** to the Bible passage of Scripture (evaluate the preacher's understanding of the Bible)? (2) Was it **relevant** to the listeners (evaluate their application)? (3) Was it **clear** in its presentation (evaluate their communication)?*

See Unit 13 of Module One for further guidelines.

What responsibilities need to be delegated? *This is important for a successful workshop. Share duties out early on. It is helpful to have someone in charge of the devotions; a timekeeper; a head of welfare; a person to liaise over any catering etc.*

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Module One **2 Timothy & the Pastoral Epistles: Preaching the Gospel & Godly Leadership**

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Unit 4. How to encounter a Bible passage (Tools)
Unit 5. 2 Timothy 1:8-12 (Encounter)
Unit 6. What is the gospel? (Reflection)
Unit 7. Sharing the gospel (Action)
Unit 8. 2 Timothy 2:1-7 (Encounter)
Unit 9. Gospel centred ministry (Reflection)
Unit 10. 2 Timothy 3:14-17 (Encounter)
Unit 11. The Bible and biblical ministry (Reflection)
Unit 12. 2 Timothy 4:1-5 (Encounter)
Unit 13. How to preach a Bible passage (Action)
Unit 14. Titus 1:5-9 (Encounter)
Unit 15. Leaders of integrity (Action)

Review questions for Module One

- Look back through the titles of the units in the module (see above). Which units had the greatest impact on you and why is that the case?

- Think back to your time in and use of the module. In what ways has your leadership been challenged and changed as a result of the module?

- In a similar way, reflect on the ways in which your church has been influenced by any teaching from the module, which you have passed on in some way.

Unit 1. The Pentateuch and the Bible's story (Tools)

Overview

Welcome to Module Two of the Basic BUILD Curriculum: *Genesis and the Pentateuch: Knowing God's Story and Leading by Faith*. This unit will introduce you to the Pentateuch and the Bible's story and, in doing so, to the module as a whole.

Outline

- A good story
- The greatest story
- The Pentateuch and the Bible's Story
- History is His-story
- God's story and our story

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. List the parts of a good story and explain how the Bible fits this pattern
2. Use examples to point out the different levels of story in the Bible
3. Point out why the Pentateuch is so important in God's story
4. State ways in which your story and the story of your church and community are part of God's story

Throughout the manual notes for Trainers are in italics. These give information and suggestions to help you facilitate the learning. The Participant Manual does not have these notes and the page numbers are different. Use the section numbers to guide the participants through the manual (for example: "Find section 1.1").

1.1 A GOOD STORY

1.1.1 Good story telling

- Can you recall a well-known story in your own local culture? It might be the story of how a group of people such as the Baganda came into being. Or it might be a story about the origins of evil. Share that story with the group.

As a group exercise select one of the most promising stories people remember. Listen carefully as a member of the group tells that story or story; then discuss the question below. If time permits repeat the process for another story from another member.

- What made the story a good story? List and describe the main ingredients in a strong story.

Guide this process and do not let the participants look at the next pages. If participants can be guided to share a cultural story that explains the origins of the world and its local people that will help the learning because we will be looking at these themes: understanding stories; understanding the Bible's story; the biblical creation story; our own worldviews, as shaped by local and cultural stories.

If there are too many stories you can get people to share some of them at other points. Cultural reconciliation stories are also important, but they can be saved for Unit 10, where we look at covenants or agreements.

1.1.2 The ingredients of a good story

You might have discovered that while the rules of storytelling vary from place to place, stories have common elements. We will focus on six of those elements:

1. A story has an **audience**, a particular group of people it is intended for.

2. A story has a **narrator**, a storyteller who tells it. The storyteller selects material and presents a certain view in order to make his point.

3. A story has a **plot**, a storyline or sequence of events which carries the story and action forwards, as one event leads to the next.

4. A story has **characters**, individuals or groups that are at the centre of the action. There is often a main character, some opposition to that character, and those who side with the main character. The characters' words are critical: they reveal the nature of the characters and give insights into the story's plot and message.

5. A story has **scenes**, places and settings that capture the action or support the plot in other ways. Scenes contribute to longer episodes: together they are the building blocks of a good story. (Just as there are episodes in a television series, with scenes making up the episode.)

6. A story has a **message** or purpose to it. The narrator has a reason for selecting material and telling the story: he tells it to make a point and share a message.

Stories have: (1) an **audience**, (2) a **narrator**, (3) a **plot**, (4) **characters**, (5) **scenes**, and (6) a **message**.

1.1.3 The plot or development of a good story

We have noticed that central to a good story is its storyline or plot: the sequence or chain of events which carries the story forwards. Often that plot follows this simple sequence:

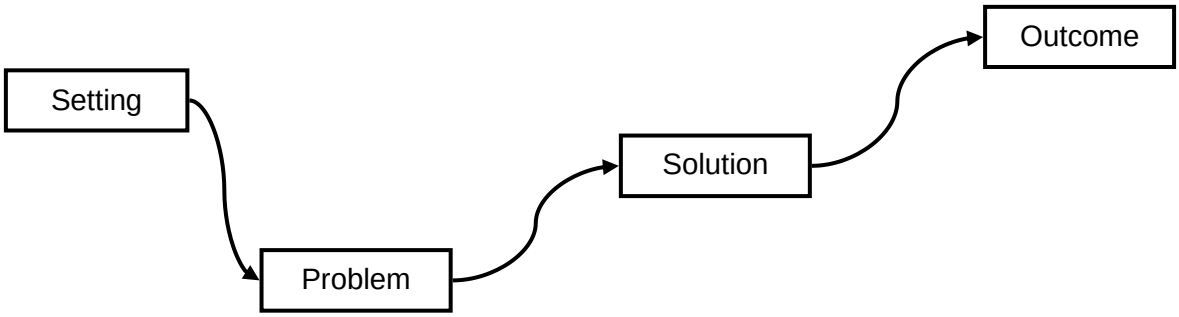
1. The **setting** or backdrop ("A long time ago there was a good king who ...")

2. The **problem** or conflict or tension of some sort that is introduced ("But the king had an evil nephew ...")

3. The **solution** to that problem or resolution of that conflict: a mystery that is solved, a problem that is overcome, or an unexpected situation that is resolved ("One day a wise man appeared...")

4. The **outcome** or result at the end ("The land enjoyed peace and harmony.")

This can be pictured as follows:



This may be a simple sequence but there are countless ways in which problems or tensions are introduced and solved or resolved. Not to mention all the stories within the stories – and the sub-plots that run through the whole story. There is the main 'STORY' and the smaller 'stories' that contribute to it. We will see that that is a helpful distinction when it comes to the Bible.

In Module One you were encouraged to tell your story or testimony – can you see how it involves those main elements and those main parts? You might like to discuss this.

1.2 THE GREATEST STORY

- Here is a question to debate: How many stories are there in the Bible?

The Bible has many stories in it. It has two main ones: the story of the OT people of God, and the story of Jesus and the NT people of God. But essentially the Bible is ONE STORY and that story is the greatest story ever told. This is explored below.

1.2.1 The Bible has one story

The Bible has one main story, God's story, the greatest story ever told. It follows the plot we have already discovered.

It has a setting – the **creation** provides the backdrop.

It introduces a problem – the **fall** is how that is often referred to.

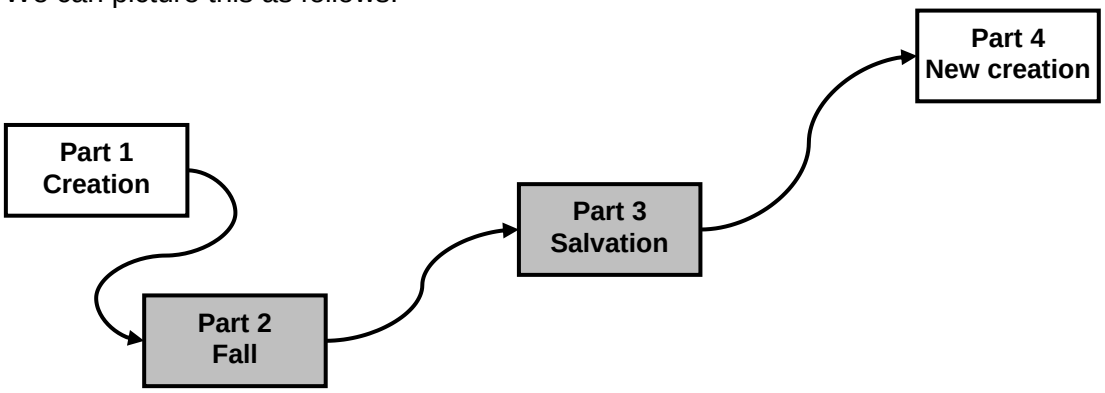
There is a deep and satisfying solution – **salvation** is the summary word for that.

Finally, God's story has a wonderful outcome – a whole **new creation**.

In other words there are four main parts to God's story:

1. **Creation** – the setting
2. **Fall** – the problem
3. **Salvation** – the solution
4. **New creation** – the outcome

We can picture this as follows:



- What title would you give for the Bible's story?

The way the story is told in the Bible as a whole means that the element of 'solution' or 'salvation' is the main focus of the book, which is why it could be given the title 'God's Story of Salvation'.

- Can you think of Bible passages that illustrate these four parts?

  The setting: Genesis 1-2
  The problem: Genesis 3
  The solution: Beginning with Genesis 12:1-3 (but with tasters before that, for example in the flood story)
  The outcome: Revelation 21:1-22:5 (but again with tasters of this at various points: in the prophets, and in Christ and his people)

1.2.2 The Bible has two stories

The Bible has a single, grand story. But it also has a number of stories within it.

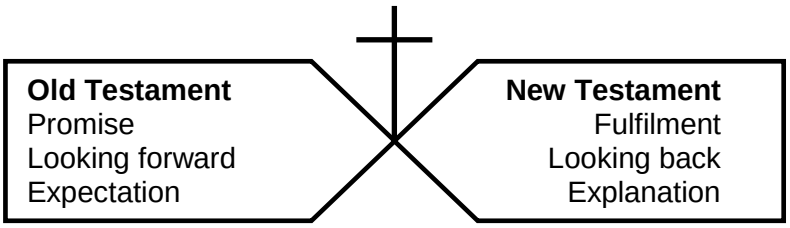
In Module One we drew attention to the fact that there are two main parts to the Bible: the Old Testament and the New Testament. We did so in the context of understanding any Bible book or passage within it: we need to 'Establish the original CONTEXT' and that involves knowing where it comes in 'the story of the Bible'.

We introduced one simple idea: "it is important to note whether the passage comes before or after Christ."

We thought about these questions:

- Is the passage in the Old Testament or New Testament?
- Is it about God's promises or the fulfilment of those promises?
- Is it looking forward to the work of Christ or looking back to what he has done.
- Is it expecting the cross and resurrection or explaining it?

And we considered this illustration:



Those two parts of the Bible can also be thought of as **two stories**. The Old Testament story and the New Testament story. One is the story of God's people Israel and one the story of God's new people, the new Israel. Each of those two stories has its own setting, problem, solution and outcome.

Discuss the following questions together, using the space below to make notes:

- Can you identify the four parts of the Old Testament story (its setting, problem, solution and outcome)? Think of Bible passages to illustrate the different parts.

  The Old Testament Story

  Setting: *Creation (Genesis 1-2)*

  Problem: *Fall (Genesis 3)*

  Solution: *The choice and mission of Israel (for example, Genesis 12:1-3, sections of Exodus, sections of the prophets such as Isaiah)*

  Outcome: *The return and restoration of Israel (for example, Ezra-Nehemiah, sections of the prophets such as Isaiah)*

- Can you identify the four parts of the New Testament story (its setting, problem, solution and outcome)? Think of Bible passages to illustrate the different parts.

  The New Testament Story

  Setting: *Israel's return to the land (Mark 1:1-3 assumes this)*

  Problem: *Israel has not returned to the Lord and the Lord has not returned to the land (Mark 1:1-3 also assumes this)*

  Solution: *The Servant of the Lord (Mark 10:45)*

  Outcome: *The Coming King, bringing the kingdom (Mark 13:26-27)*

If the Bible is one story but also has two stories, then those two stories join together to form the one story. We will consider this more in Unit 12, 'Jesus and the Old Testament'. But begin to think about it now:

- How does the Bible join the two stories together – the Old Testament story and the New Testament story?

  The very simplest place to go to consider this is the end of the Old Testament and the beginning of the New Testament.

  The last chapter of the Old Testament, Malachi 4 speaks of the "great and dreadful day of the Lord" (v 5), with a message of judgment and hope ("for you who revere my name, the sun of righteousness will rise with healing in its rays" (v 2).

  The first chapter of the New Testament, Matthew 1, brings us "the genealogy of Jesus the Messiah the son of David, the son of Abraham" the one who fulfils God's promises.

1.2.3 The Bible has many stories

But there are also many stories in the Bible, each with its own plot. In fact there are dozens of stories within it: it is both the simplest story in the world and the richest and most varied.

- Which is your favourite story in the Bible? Share this briefly with someone else.

In Unit Two we will see how important it is to keep these three 'levels' in mind:

1. The Bible's one big STORY;
2. The two main stories in the Bible;
3. The many stories in the Bible.

It is helpful to write 'STORY' in large capital letters for the single STORY of the Bible and to write 'stories' in small lower-case letters below it to help people remember that there is one STORY and many stories.

1.3 THE PENTATEUCH AND THE BIBLE'S STORY

1.3.1 What is the Pentateuch?

The Pentateuch, meaning the 'five volumes' is a single body of writing made up of the first five books of the Bible, 'the five books of Moses': Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus and Numbers.

In the Hebrew Bible it is known as 'The Law', the first of the three main sections of the Hebrew Scriptures: The Law, The Prophets and The Writings.

The Pentateuch provides the foundation for the whole Bible and reveals the God of the Bible and his purposes.

Genesis	Exodus	Leviticus	Numbers	Deut.
The God who makes and keeps promises	The God who delivers and is with his people	The God who is holy and commands sacrifice for sin	The God who guides and judges his people	The God who chooses and is gracious to his people

1.3.2 Where does the Pentateuch fit in to the Bible's story?

Discuss how the Pentateuch relates to the 'four parts' of the Bible's STORY:

- Where and how does the Pentateuch describe the creation (setting) and the fall (problem)? Why are those events so important in the five books?
- Where and how do they begin to describe the solution (salvation)
- Can you think of any ways in which the Pentateuch points ahead to the New Creation (outcome) of the STORY?

The Pentateuch has enormous significance within the Bible's story as it describes the setting (creation), the problem (fall), and begins to describe the solution (salvation), and outcome (New Creation).

Genesis 1 and 2 describe the setting (creation) (1:1 "In the beginning God...")
Genesis 3-11 introduces the problem (fall) and its consequences. That provides a backdrop for the whole of the Pentateuch and the whole of the Bible (3:1 "Now the serpent...")
Genesis 12 begins to describe the solution (salvation) and in doing so even hints at and looks forward to the outcome (New Creation) (12:1 "The LORD had said to Abram...").

You could ask where we first have a taster of salvation. Genesis 3:15 and 3:21 give tasters of that, as does the story of the flood in Genesis 6-9. In other words it is not all neatly divided up. Like a well-crafted story it gives indications of what is to come.

And note, of course, that the Pentateuch is itself a single story, one of the most important in the Bible, with many stories within it, and has a single main author, Moses.

1.4 HISTORY IS HIS-STORY

From a human point of view history looks messy and is hard or impossible to understand. But God's story, the Bible's story, lies behind it. God's story of salvation history is unfolding day-by-day throughout history. And that is the case whether we can understand it or not.

The history of Israel makes that clear: the Bible is full of ways in which God works within human history. The storytellers of Israel have God-given insight into the complexity of history and how God's purposes are being fulfilled within it. God is in control of it and directing it to serve his plans. In other words 'history is his-story'.

We have not reached the end of history yet, but we know the ending that God has planned – not in detail but in outline. And we know that in the meantime he is in charge

and we have nothing to fear. Module 10 will take this further as it looks at the book of Revelation.

1.5 GOD'S STORY AND OUR STORY

You will not find your story or the story of your church or the story of your community in the Bible. But they are linked to God's great plan of salvation and the Bible's story, which continues to unfold.

- In what ways is your story linked to God's great story? How are you caught up in this amazing drama?

- The subtitle of this module is "Knowing God's Story and Leading by Faith". We need to learn to lead ourselves, our families and our churches through difficult times and into the future that God has planned. How do these links between God's story and your story help you in your life and leadership?

Extra: You might want to think back to what you learnt in Module One, Unit 6 about your testimony and the gospel as you think about God's story and your story.

- How does the fact that God's story and your story are connected help you to share your testimony clearly and with great confidence?

- Discuss how you can improve the presentation of your testimony now we have thought about the ingredients of a good story?

Unit 2. Genesis 12:1-9 and God's salvation plan (Tools)

Overview

Genesis 12:1-9, the call of Abram, is one of the most important passages in the Bible. The promises God makes to Abram in Genesis 12:1-3 launch God's plan of salvation and, in doing so, provide a framework for exploring the whole of the story of the Bible. This unit explores that plan and explores the book of Genesis as a whole.

Outline

- Studying Genesis 12:1-9
- Four golden threads running through the Bible's story
- Four stages in the salvation part of the story
- Combining the stages and threads in the salvation part
- Establishing the context of the book of Genesis
- Discovering the content of the book of Genesis
- Making connections and teaching the content today

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Recall the four threads in the promises of Genesis 12:1-3
2. Outline the different stages in the solution (salvation) to the problem in the Bible's story
3. Explain the plan of salvation to a fellow believer

2.1 STUDYING GENESIS 12:1-9

It is impossible to overstate the importance of Genesis 12:1-9. It sits at the beginning of the 'solution' or 'salvation' section of the Bible's story that we explored in the previous unit. Genesis 12:1-9 introduces the rest of the story by revealing the key elements in God's plan of salvation, and it also helps us to interpret what has come before it because it sets out the elements or threads that run through the entire story. This is why we will pay special attention to Genesis 12:1-9 in this unit.

Look at Genesis 12:1-9 and discuss these questions together:

- These verses report what "the Lord had said to Abram". What type of message did God give Abram? For example, was it a command or a warning or a promise or some other kind of message or a combination? Explain your answer.

  It was a command with a promise (which is then, with the motivation of the promise, obeyed in faith, v 4)

- Can you identify the different elements of God's promise to Abraham in vv 1-3? Try and name and explain these different parts of the message.

  There are different ways of putting this, but throughout this module, and the BUILD curriculum we will follow these four elements: 1. People, 2. Place, 3. Presence, 4. Purpose. Show how they come from the passage (see below):

1 The LORD had said to Abram, 'Go
from your country, your people
and your father's household to the land *(PLACE)*
I will show you
2 'I will make you into a great nation *(PEOPLE)*
and I will bless you;
I will make your name great,
and you will be a blessing.
3 I will bless those who bless you,
and whoever curses you I will curse; *(PRESENCE)*
and all peoples on earth
will be blessed through you.' *(PURPOSE)*

Explain these a little more:

1. People (v. 2)
We put this element first because God begins with Abram, a person who will form a new people (he has already been told to leave his former people in v. 1).

2. Place (v. 1)
God promises Abram a land, a promise he confirms in v. 7.

3. Presence (v. 2-3)
God's blessing is first and foremost his own presence with his people. If this is at all unclear here, it is an element that the Pentateuch will reveal in due course (Exodus 34:15-16). This blessing of God's presence with his people leads to other forms of blessing, but it is all rooted in his gracious favour.

4. Purpose (v. 3)
God's blessing to Abram: his people, his place, his presence and the prosperity that comes with that is for sharing. God's people have a purpose from the very beginning. In other words mission is a vital part of the Bible's story of salvation, from start to finish.

- Look on to vv. 4-9. How do these verses begin to set the promises of vv. 1-3 in motion? In what ways do they give a preview of the story of Genesis, the Pentateuch, the Old Testament and the Bible as a whole?

  In vv4-9. Abram then obeys and goes to the land of Canaan. God appears to him and confirms the promise. He continues on, builds a place of worship and relates to the Lord. All this is a little glimpse and overview of the whole story. But because the Canaanites are in the land he moves on to the Negev (the desert) and in the next verse (10) heads for Egypt, which is also a foretaste of the story of the Pentateuch, the Old Testament and the Bible as a whole.

2.2 FOUR GOLDEN THREADS IN THE BIBLE'S STORY

2.2.1 A summary of the four threads

In Genesis 12:1-9 we have identified four elements to God's promise, which are like four golden threads running through the Bible's story. They run through the Bible's plot or storyline from start to finish and hold it together. They are as follows:

1. God's promise of a **people**
2. God's promise of a **place**
3. God's promise of his **presence**
4. God's promise of a **purpose**

Your trainer will illustrate these on a board or flipchart, copy that idea below:

Write START and FINISH on the far left and far right of a board or flipchart. Draw four threads running from left to right to connect them. Explain that the Bible's story is defined and held together by how God's people grow and change, by how the promise of a place for them develops, by how God's presence with them is fulfilled, and by the story of God's mission to the world.

2.2.2 How do the four threads run through the Bible's story?

Look at the table and think through how each element or thread runs through the story as a whole. Short summaries are given in the table. Your trainer can unpack or explain some of this if necessary.

	Creation	**Fall**	**Salvation**	**New Creation**
People	Adam and Eve are the sum of God's people	Division between God's people	Israel and then the church, God's new Israel	God's renewed people from all nations
Place	Eden, the perfect place for God's people to dwell	Beyond Eden. They are thrown out of the garden	The relationship with the land varies	A new heavens and new earth
Presence	God is with them in the garden	They are separated from God's presence	The nature of God's presence varies too	God is with his people
Purpose	They are to be fruitful, and to rule and subdue	Their work becomes hard	The extent of their wider mission varies	Worship and work in the new creation

- If time permits looks at Genesis 1-2 and see if you can identify those four threads in the story of creation. Then look at Genesis 3 and see if you can notice those same elements in the story of the fall.

2.3 FOUR STAGES IN THE SALVATION PART OF THE BIBLE'S STORY

2.3.1 Four parts, four threads, and four stages of salvation

The things we are looking at come in groups of four.

First, there are four parts to the Bible's story:

1. Creation
2. Fall
3. Salvation
4. New Creation

Second, there are four threads that run through that story:

1. People
2. Place
3. Presence
4. Purpose

But there is one more group of four things to remember. We will now see that the salvation part of the Bible's story itself has four stages to it.

We have already seen that the 'solution' or salvation part of the Bible's story is itself a long drama, with a number of stories within it. Because it is long it is helpful to break this part of the story into four stages. We will use those four stages throughout the BUILD curriculum when looking at God's plan of salvation.

2.3.2 The four stages in the salvation part of the Bible's story

We already have four words beginning with the letter 'P' for the four threads.

We will now add another four words beginning with the letter 'P' for the four stages in the salvation part of the story.

They are wonderful words that are full of meaning: promised, pictured, prophesied and proclaimed.

1. God's salvation is **promised**

2. God's salvation is **pictured**

3. God's salvation is **prophesied**

4. God's salvation is **proclaimed**

2.3.3 The four stages in God's story of salvation described

The four stages in God's story of salvation can be described as follows:

1. God's salvation PROMISED
We have seen how that promise comes to Abram. Genesis fleshes out that promise in the form of a family and the promise is repeated a number of times at different points in the book. We will be looking at that promise in this module, Module Two. If you are going to look at one passage, **Genesis 12:1-3** is the key.

2. God's salvation PICTURED
Exodus paints a picture or model of salvation as a people, Israel, is rescued, the promise is renewed, the Law given and God comes to dwell with them, pictured by his glory filling the tabernacle (Exodus 40:35). Leviticus builds on that with the explanation of the sacrifices and the exposition of the Law. Numbers tests the relationship and Deuteronomy recaps it all on the edge of the land (Deuteronomy means 'second law'). This module not only looks at the promise of salvation, but also begins to develop this picture.

Joshua to Esther is the lengthy story of how that picture develops in the land. That includes the establishment of the monarchy, the division of the kingdom, the exile from the land and the return to the land. Module Four looks at the way this picture develops and in doing so builds on the foundation of the Old Testament story that this module provides.

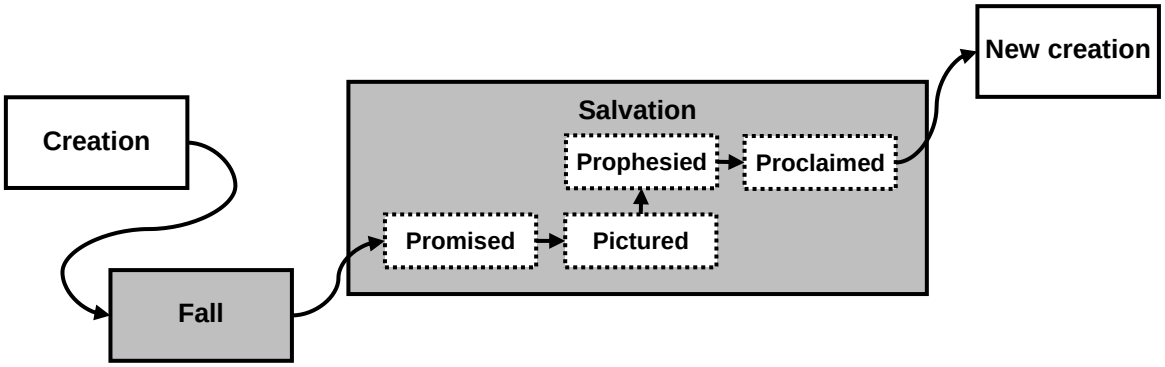
The Psalms (Module Six) and the Wisdom writing (Module Eight) are set in and reflect on the story of the land in different ways. If you are going to look at one passage, **Exodus 19:5-6** is a reminder of God's presence with and through his people.

3. God's salvation PROPHESIED
This 'stage' in the story runs at the same time as, or parallel to, the story of the land, God's place. But it is important to separate it out as the prophets look beyond the immediate situation to the future. They do this by looking back to the **promise** of salvation and compare the current '**picture'** or situation with all its flaws and weakness, and look forward to the **proclamation** of that salvation. Module Nine looks at this stage of salvation, **prophecy**. If you are going to look at one passage, **Isaiah 65:17-25** is a vision of God's future salvation.

4. God's salvation PROCLAIMED
Finally God's salvation is proclaimed by the Lord Jesus, who fulfils all the elements of the solution and leads the new people of God into the New Creation – the King and his Kingdom. Modules Three, Five, Seven and Ten look at the announcement and fulfilment of that Kingdom. If you are going to look at one passage, **Mark 1:14-15** announces the Kingdom of God.

2.3.4 A diagram of the four stages of God's salvation

The four stages can be pictured as follows:



In summary:

1. God's salvation is **promised** – a word to Abram that God begins to fulfil
2. God's salvation is **pictured** – a nation, Israel, who illustrate that salvation
3. God's salvation is **prophesied** – a hope for a rebellious people and their land
4. God's salvation is **proclaimed** – a Saviour, Jesus, the King of the Kingdom

2.4 UNDERSTANDING THE BOOK OF GENESIS

Genesis 12:1-9 helps us to understand the whole book of Genesis. Following the four threads of God's promises and knowing the four stages in the plan of Salvation gives us a more detailed framework for understanding the Bible's story. Our greater understanding of the Bible's story helps us to see more clearly where a Bible book fits into the Bible as a whole, which means we can understand a book in greater depth.

In Unit 2 of Module One we learnt **four steps for understanding a Bible book**. Can you remember them? Here they are again in the summary form:

FOUR STEPS FOR UNDERSTANDING A BIBLE BOOK

Step 1: Establish the original CONTEXT of the book
- Where does the book fit in the Bible's **story**?
- What **situation** was the book was written for?
- What **style** of writing was it written in?

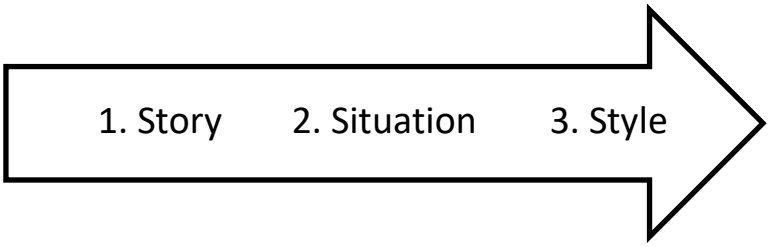
Step 2: Discover the CONTENT of the book
- What is the **structure** of the book?
- What are the main **themes** of the book?
- What is the **message** of the book?
- What is the **purpose** of the book?

Step 3: Make the CONNECTIONS with our situation today
- What **connections** are there with our situation today?

Step 4: Teach the CONTENT of the book today
- What **main points** would you make?
- How would you **raise these issues** with your listeners?

We will now apply these to the book of Genesis, concentrating on the first two steps.

Remember the process:



2.4.1 Where does the book of Genesis fit in the Bible's <u>story</u>?

In order to discover where any book of the Bible fits in the story, we need to remember the three sets of four things:

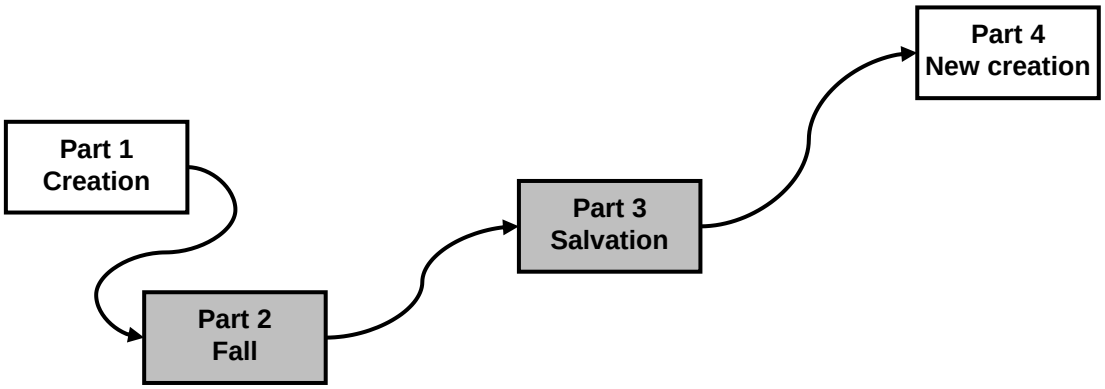
The four **parts** of the Bible's story

The four **stages** in the salvation part of the Bible's story

The four **threads** running through the Bible's story – the elements of the promise

First, where does the book fit in relation to <u>the four parts</u> of the Bible's story?

1. **Creation** – the setting
2. **Fall** – the problem
3. **Salvation** – the solution
4. **New creation** – the outcome

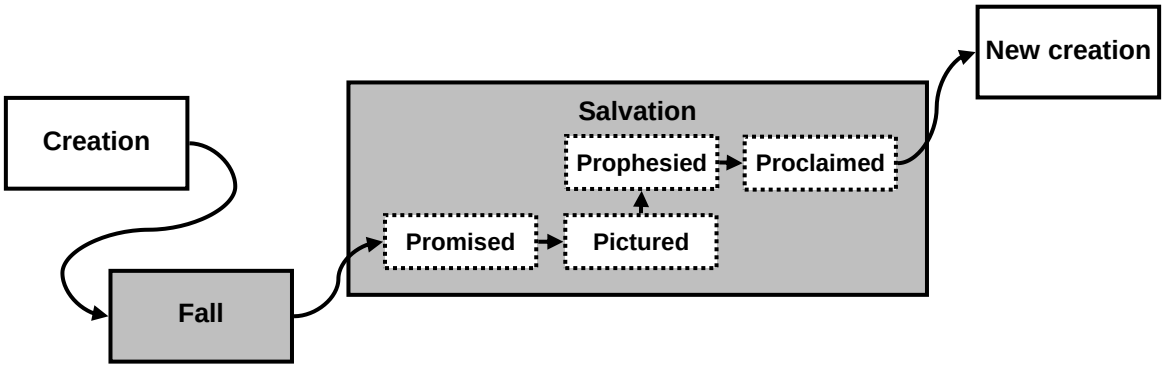


- Where does the book of Genesis fit within **the story of the Bible as a whole**? How does it relate to the <u>creation</u>, to the fall, to <u>salvation</u>, and to the <u>new creation</u>?

Genesis is a very important book indeed. In Chapters 1 and 2 it provides the <u>setting</u> of Creation, in Chapters 3-11 it introduces the <u>problem</u> of the Fall and its effects, in Chapters 12-50 it records how the <u>solution</u>, God's plan of Salvation, is set in motion. And in providing the picture of Creation it gives a blueprint for the New Creation, the <u>outcome</u> of salvation.

Second, where does the book fit in relation to <u>the four stages</u> in the salvation part of the Bible's story?

1. God's salvation is **promised** – a word to Abram that God begins to fulfil
2. God's salvation is **pictured** – a nation, Israel, who illustrate that salvation
3. God's salvation is **prophesied** – a hope for a rebellious people and their land
4. God's salvation is **proclaimed** – a Saviour, Jesus, the King of the Kingdom



- Discuss where the book comes **in the salvation part of the Bible's story**. In other words, how does it relate to salvation promised, then pictured, then prophesied and then proclaimed?

Genesis launches and looks at the promises and only points forward to the other stages.

Third, how does the book relate to the four threads running through the Bible's story?

1. God's promise of a **people** – a nation under his care

2. God's promise of a **place** – a land in which to belong

3. God's promise of his **presence** – a covenant relationship to enjoy

4. God's promise of a **purpose** – a mission to accomplish

- Discuss each of **the four threads of the promise** and the extent to which they have been fulfilled in and by the time of the book. How are each of these elements progressing: a people, a place, God's presence, and a purpose?

Genesis provides the background for all of these threads through Chapters 1-2, and the way in which they are lost in Chapter 3. It then has indications of these in the story of the flood, and promises them to Abraham in Genesis 12:1-3. The promise of a people is gradually fleshed out through the book, with pointers to God's land, God's presence and the purpose of God's people.

2.4.2 What situation was the book of Genesis written for?

Remember the five questions from Module One and answer them in relation to the Book of Genesis: Who? Where? What? Why? When?

Who? *It was written for God's people, Israel.*

Where? *It was written for them as they lived in the land of Canaan.*

What? *It was written as an account of the origins of God's world, and God's people.*

Why? *It was written so that they would know who their God is and who they are in the midst of the surrounding nations.*

When? *It was probably written about 1,800 BC.*

2.4.3 What style of writing was the Book of Genesis written in?

In Unit 1 we learnt about stories. Genesis is a story that is made up of a number of stories. In Unit 3 we will see how that changes the way we read Genesis when we look at the Steps of Scripture Sculpture.

2.5 DISCOVERING THE CONTENT OF THE BOOK OF GENESIS

We have begun to discover some of the content of the book as we have looked at Genesis 12:1-9. Some further work will help us as we look in more detail at passages in the book.

2.5.1 What is the structure of the book?

Genesis is a book of beginnings. 1:1 – 2:3 sets the scene and introduces the book, the Pentateuch, the Old Testament and the Bible itself.

After this introduction the book is built around two main divisions: the beginning of humanity (an ancient history) and the beginning of Israel (the history of the Patriarchs or fathers of the nation).

And within each of those divisions there are five sections, each beginning with the phrase "This is the account of …".

That gives the clear structure, below:

Introduction

1:1 – 2:3	"In the beginning" – setting the scene

1. The Beginnings of Humanity

2:4 – 4:26	The account of the heavens and the earth
5:1 – 6:8	The account of Adam
6:9 – 9:26	The account of Noah
9:27 – 11:9	The account of the sons of Noah
11:10 – 11:26	The account of Shem

2. The Beginnings of Israel

11:27 – 25:11	The account of Terah (and his son Abraham)
25:12 – 18	The account of Ishmael
25:19 – 35:29	The account of Isaac
36:1 – 37:1	The account of Esau
37:2 – 50:26	The account of Jacob

Conclusion

48.1 – 50:26	Embedded within the account of Jacob

Note that the **conclusion** is part of the final section. Take a look at Genesis 50:22-26 and see how it masterfully draws together the threads of the book and points forward to Exodus (you can then turn over to Exodus 1:1-7 and see how Exodus picks up the story). If time permits look too at Genesis 49:1-28, which looks more closely at the future of Israel. Judah plays the central role (49:8-12), with verse 10 at the heart of that prophecy: "The sceptre will not depart from Judah…"

2.5.2 What are the main <u>themes</u> of the book?

We are already beginning to see a number of themes. Can you list them?

2.5.3 What is the <u>message</u> of the book?

From what we have seen so far, complete this sentence: The message of the book of Genesis is that….

2.5.4 What is the <u>purpose</u> of the book?

From what we have seen so far, complete this sentence: The purpose of the book is to…

2.6 MAKING CONNECTIONS AND TEACHING THE CONTENT TODAY

Truly understanding a book of the Bible means finishing the four steps and making connections with our situation and teaching the content today.

We will consider this as we look at specific passages from within Genesis. But to end this unit turn to someone else or form a small group and discuss these questions, which will remind you of some of the earlier content of the unit and help you to begin to apply Genesis:

- What new truths have you discovered about God himself as we have considered his plan of salvation?

- How do those new things encourage you to continue, as Abram did (Genesis 12:9) in your journey of faith?

- Hebrews 11:8-10 is a commentary on these verses in Genesis. You might like to read and reflect on them as you pray.

2.7 EXTRA: COMBINING THE THREADS AND STAGES OF SALVATION

*This extra work is an opportunity to apply the principles of the unit to the Bible as a whole. The idea is to see how **the four golden threads** of God's promise run through **the four stages of salvation**, with reference to specific Bible passages. You might like to share out the four different threads to four different groups in order to spread the load.*

In order to understand the Bible's overall story it is helpful to keep the **four threads of salvation** and the **four stages of salvation** in mind as you look through your Bible. We will keep referring back to this idea as we go through the BUILD course.

This is an extra piece of learning that you can give more time to now. This will also help you to produce some reference material for yourself. If time is limited you can choose to complete this later. Your facilitator will guide you.

Have a close look at the table on the next page.

You will see there are 16 boxes, each with a number/letter code, a title and a space to fill. In order to fill in each space you will need to consider and answer these questions:

- First, what is happening to this thread of **God's promise** at this stage of **God's salvation** in the Bible's story?

- Second, can you provide a Bible passage or passages from the relevant part of the story, which demonstrate and illustrate your point?

For example, look at box 1A. That box sits in the row that follows the first golden thread: **God's promise of a <u>people</u>**. And it also sits in the column dedicated to the first stage of salvation: **God's salvation <u>promised</u>**. Hence the title: '**1A. God's people promised**'.

That title is shorthand for the following idea. A golden thread in the overall promise is **God's promise of a <u>people</u>** who will grow and develop. What does that look like in the first stage of **God's salvation <u>promised</u>** (particularly in Gen 12-50)? And what verses illustrate that point? As a result of answering those questions, in box 1A we can say this:

> We see this thread in Gen 12:2 and at other moments in Genesis (15:1-21; 17:1-27). By the end of the book Abraham's descendants have increased and God's people are taking shape (50:22-23).

There is of course much to discuss around that short summary squeezed into that box!

For another example, look at box 2B: '**God's place pictured**'. When it comes to the second golden thread, **God's promise of a <u>place</u>**, in the second stage, **God's salvation <u>pictured</u>**, chapters 13 and 14 in the book of Numbers are a good place to start. Considering how God's promise of a place, a land, is developing in the picture of God's salvation, we can say this in box 2B:

> 12 leaders explore the land in Num 13. But due to rebellion the land will not be entered for 40 years (14:34). Joshua describes the conquest, a mixed picture that leads into the rest of the OT story.

In other words, these sixteen boxes provide a way in which the whole story of the Bible can be explored. See how you get on.

	God's salvation… A. Promised	God's salvation… B. Pictured	God's salvation… C. Prophesied	God's salvation… D. Proclaimed
God's promise of… 1. A people	**1A. God's people promised** We see this thread in Gen 12:2 and at other moments in Genesis (15:1-21; 17:1-27). By the end of the book Abraham's descendants have increased and God's people are taking shape (50:22-23).	**1B. God's people pictured** *In Exod 19 and 20 God's recently rescued people are gathered before God to receive his covenant as "a holy nation" (19:1-6). This picture of God's people is developed through the OT story.*	**1C. God's people prophesied** *From the depths of sin and exile Isaiah and the prophets look forward to a new and renewed people of God gathered from Israel and the nations around their true king (e.g. Isa 11:10-16).*	**1D. God's people proclaimed** *Matthew 28:16-20 draws together the message of Jesus' gospel about this thread: a new people forming around a new Israel, and from all nations around the person of Jesus and his teaching.*
God's promise of… 2. A place	**2A. God's place promised** *In Gen 12:1. Then in 12.5-7 Abram reaches Canaan, worships and travels on. Joseph remembers the promise on his deathbed but the book ends with his body in Egypt, far from the Land (50:24-26).*	**2B. God's place pictured** 12 leaders explore the land in Num 13. But due to rebellion the land will not be entered for 40 years (14:34). Joshua describes the conquest, a mixed picture that leads into the rest of the OT story.	**2C. God's place prophesied** *Isaiah and the prophets point to the hope of a new heavens and new earth, a renewed and restored creation (Isa 65:17-25). God's temple is the focal point of that holy place (66:20)*	**2D. God's place proclaimed** *The kingdom of God is at hand in Jesus and his good news (Mark 1:14-15). Jesus is one greater than the temple (John 2:19-21), and he is the risen life (11:25), the one who prepares a place for us (14:3).*
God's promise of… 3. His presence	**3A. God's presence promised** *In Gen 12:1-3 God's blessing, his presence with his people, is promised. This is repeated through the book. One symbol of God's glory is introduced in 15.17 (fire – in the form of a blazing torch).*	**3B. God's presence pictured** *Exodus pictures God's presence: from the burning bush of 3:2, and the pillar of cloud and fire leading the people (13:21), to God's glory filling his tabernacle (40:34), it is a mark of God's people (33:15).*	**3C. God's presence prophesied** *The prophets point to the glory of God with his people. Ezekiel is framed by God's glory leaving his sinful people (8-10) but returning by grace as a river from the temple (47:1-12). See, too, Hab 2:14.*	**3D. God's presence proclaimed** *Jesus brings God's very presence to within his people, a spring of living water (John 4:14). Jesus is God's fiery pillar to guide us (8:12), and he brings God's empowering presence, his Holy Spirit (20:22).*
God's promise of… 4. A purpose	**4A. God's purpose promised** *In Gen 12:3 Abram is promised: "all peoples on earth will be blessed through you". This is repeated through stories and covenants, and illustrated at the end with many lives saved (50:20).*	**4B. God's purpose pictured** *Exodus reveals God's people as a holy people for the nations (19:5-6). Their distinctive life of justice reaches a peak in 1 Kgs 10: the wisdom of Solomon draws the world to Israel and their God.*	**4C. God's purpose prophesied** *Isaiah begins with the nations streaming to God's place (2:2), and ends with that vision enlarged, including an echo of Solomon's drawing the Queen of Sheba to Israel (60:1-7).*	**4D. God's purpose proclaimed** *Jesus comes into the world on a loving mission (John 3:16). He fulfils Israel's purpose as light to the world (8:12). He strengthens and sends his people on that same mission to the world (20:21).*

Unit 3. Understanding Bible stories (Tools)

Overview

This unit adapts the steps of how to encounter a passage of the Bible that we learnt in Module One and applies them to Old Testament stories, using Genesis 12:10-20 as an example.

Outline

- The importance of Bible stories
- Introducing Bible stories
- Adapting and applying the steps of encountering a Bible passage to Bible stories
- Worksheet for Encountering Genesis 12:10-20 – Step 1
- Worksheet for Encountering Genesis 12:10-20 – Steps 2 to 4
- Responding to the message of Genesis 12:10-20

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Explain why stories are so important in the Bible
2. Apply what you learnt about stories in Unit 1 to the skill of understanding Bible stories
3. Follow and apply the four steps of Encountering a Bible passage to a passage from Genesis yourself
4. Explain and apply the message of Genesis 12:10-20

This unit builds on Unit 3 of Module One, where we learnt how to encounter a passage of the Bible.

3.1 THE IMPORTANCE OF BIBLE STORIES

Unit 1 introduced stories and the big story the Bible tells. It noted that the **one** story of the Bible can be divided into the **two** stories of God's people, Israel, and God's new people, the church. And those stories are made up of the Bible's **many** stories.

Not only does the whole of Scripture tell a story, but story **as a type of writing**, 'narrative' as it is known, is the Bible's most common form of literature. 40% of the Old Testament is in the form of story and that is even more important given that the Old Testament itself contributes three quarters' of the Bible's material.

Look at the 'contents' page of your Bible. Our Old Testament can be divided into three main sections:

- **Genesis to Esther** tells the story of Israel. That telling of the story contains poetry and law and wisdom and prophecy, but it is mainly written as story. Those other types of writing depend on the story and are embedded in it.

- **Job to Song of Songs**, containing the Wisdom and Psalms of Israel, is set in that story.

- **Isaiah to Malachi** are the Major and Minor Prophets of Israel. They are also set in the context of the OT story

And looking at the New Testament, much of that, too, is written in narrative form. In Unit 3 of Module One we learnt that 2 Timothy emphasises the central place of the Bible and its gospel. It is essential that anyone who leads, teaches and cares for a congregation is someone "who correctly handles the word of truth" (2 Tim 2:15). It is therefore very important that we know how to handle story.

We will use Genesis 12:10-20 as a sample text. Read through that passage together now in your bibles or by using the worksheet in Section 3.4, below.

3.2 INTRODUCING BIBLE STORIES

3.2.1 Six things to know about Bible stories

In order to understand Bible stories we need to apply what we began to find out about stories in Unit 1. Here are six things you need to know and take into the four steps of encountering Bible stories. These build on what we have already learnt. Remember, stories have: (1) an **audience**, (2) a **narrator**, (3) a **plot**, (4) **characters**, (5) **scenes**, and (6) a **message**.

1. Audience. A story has an audience it is intended and shaped for. As we read a story in the Bible we need to look for indications of the situation that audience faced, the situation of God's people at that time.

> For example Genesis was written for God's people surrounded by Canaanite and other cultures, with their beliefs about the world, its gods and its beginnings. It is written to a people who are called to be different and who need to know what it means to be set apart, to be God's holy people.

2. Narrator. A story has a narrator or storyteller who tells it. The narrator selects the material and presents a certain view in order to make his point. Therefore as we read Bible stories we need to note what it is the storyteller selects, particularly through any repetition of words, phrases and ideas, and the viewpoint he presents.

> Remember, too, that because Scripture is God's word through human words the ultimate storyteller is God himself. The Bible is his story, and every Bible story is part of that greater story. Look out for God's perspective on events. (Or listen out for it: remember the stories were designed be told to a group rather than read by individuals.)
>
> In Genesis 12:10-20 the narrator tells the story from Abram's perspective. But God's viewpoint is there in v. 17: "But the LORD inflicted serious diseases..."

3. Plot. A story has a plot or sequence of events that the narrator uses. We saw in Unit 1 that this is often a variation on: setting; problem; resolution; outcome.

> There are elements of that in the Story of Abraham and its various episodes. Look at Gen 12:10-20. The setting is there in v. 10 and the problem or tension is introduced in vv. 11-13. That tension is heightened (rather than resolved) in vv. 14-16 before it is resolved, dramatically, in vv. 17-19. The outcome, in v. 20, is they are expelled from Egypt, and so the Story of Abraham moves on.

4. Characters. In this plot the **characters** are central and their actions and words are of great importance. Note:

- These characters often come in pairs, sometimes in contrast to one another.
- Often as the action unfolds there is a main character, some opposition, and those who side with the main character.
- And 'character' is a helpful reminder that it is the character, or moral nature, or the characters that is revealed through their discussions and decisions.
- The characters are not perfect: they are not usually examples to follow but are players in God's story (unless the story clearly points to their example).
- God is the greatest character in Bible stories; even if he is sometimes hidden, he is the hero of the day.

  Note, for example, Abram and Sarai in Scene 1 of Gen 12:10-20, and Abram's unclear morality in the decision he shares with his wife. Abram and Pharaoh then take centre stage in Scene 2, with the tension and suspense created by Abram's decision. In Scene 3 the Lord, the hero, intervenes, which then leads to the conflict between Pharaoh and Abram.

5. Scenes. A story has **scenes** that capture the action. These short scenes often contribute to episodes, and these are the building blocks of a good story. As with a drama on television or video there may be an overall story but it can be broken down into a number of episodes and those episodes have a number of different scenes. The scenes in Biblical stories are particularly important.

For example, the Story of Abraham (Genesis 11:27 to 25:11) has 20 Episodes (can you list them?). Genesis 12:10-20 is Episode 3. Episode 3, which we could call 'In Egypt' has 3 scenes in it: after the introduction (v. 10) vv. 11-13 is Scene 1 'Abram's fears'; vv. 14-16 is Scene 2 'Abram's fears fulfilled'; and vv. 17-19 'Pharaoh's reaction', before the conclusion or final scene of them being driven away.

6. Message. Summarising what we have seen so far: in addressing his **audience**, the **narrator** has a **plot** that unfolds, in which **characters** speak and act in the setting of the various **scenes**. But biblical stories are not just for entertainment (they are entertaining and grab our attention), they have a **message** or purpose. The narrator has a reason for telling the story and, through all of the above, he tells it to make a point. Note:

- The message is not stated obviously but is often implied. That does not mean it is unclear or hidden. It means that if we listen carefully we will get the point. For example, in Genesis 12:10-20 the point is that God is in charge and is keeping the promises of the previous verses (Gen. 12:1-9) despite Abram's questionable behaviour. God continues to bless him nonetheless (Abram leaves 'with everything he had').

- Stories work at a number of levels, as we have already been seeing. This short Episode ('Abraham's Adventures in Egypt') contributes to the 'Story of Abraham' (God's promises being fleshed out) and the 'Story of Genesis' (God's stories being fleshed out and followed through, through a family that is created and saved). That story contributes to the 'Story of the Pentateuch', which contributes to the 'Story of the Old Testament', which contributes to the 'Story of the Bible'!

This is important for Christian readers and leaders, teachers and preachers. We want to see how an individual story relates to God's story, with its climax in Christ, who is Lord of all.

Genesis 12:10-20 contributes to the story of Genesis. But it anticipates the Exodus story (the adventures of God's People in Egypt and their expulsion) and ultimately looks forward to the God who will keep all his promises in Christ.

3.2.2 Things to avoid and things to do when reading Bible stories

In looking at six things to know about Bible stories we have hinted at a number of things to avoid. These are given below, along with things to do:

1. Do not assume that all the characters are examples to follow.

Do expect to find real life illustrations of teaching found elsewhere in Scripture.

2. Do not expect explicit moral teaching – other parts of the Bible are full of direct teaching.

Do expect insight into God's purposes as he tells his story through history.

3. Do not look for hidden meanings behind the stories and spice up the plain meaning.

Do build a picture of God's character and plan.

4. Do not read the stories as though the message only applies to you.

Do read them looking for the message for the original hearers and then apply it to your church and culture and self.

5. Do not read your culture and customs into the text.

Do think about the story in context before drawing conclusions.

6. Do not apply specific events and actions to your situation.

Do look for general principles to apply.

We will keep these in mind throughout the module as we consider different stories in the Pentateuch.

3.3 ADAPTING THE STEPS OF ENCOUNTERING A PASSAGE FOR A STORY

Keeping what we have learnt above in mind we will now adapt the steps of encountering a Bible passage that we learnt in Module One and apply them to Bible stories.

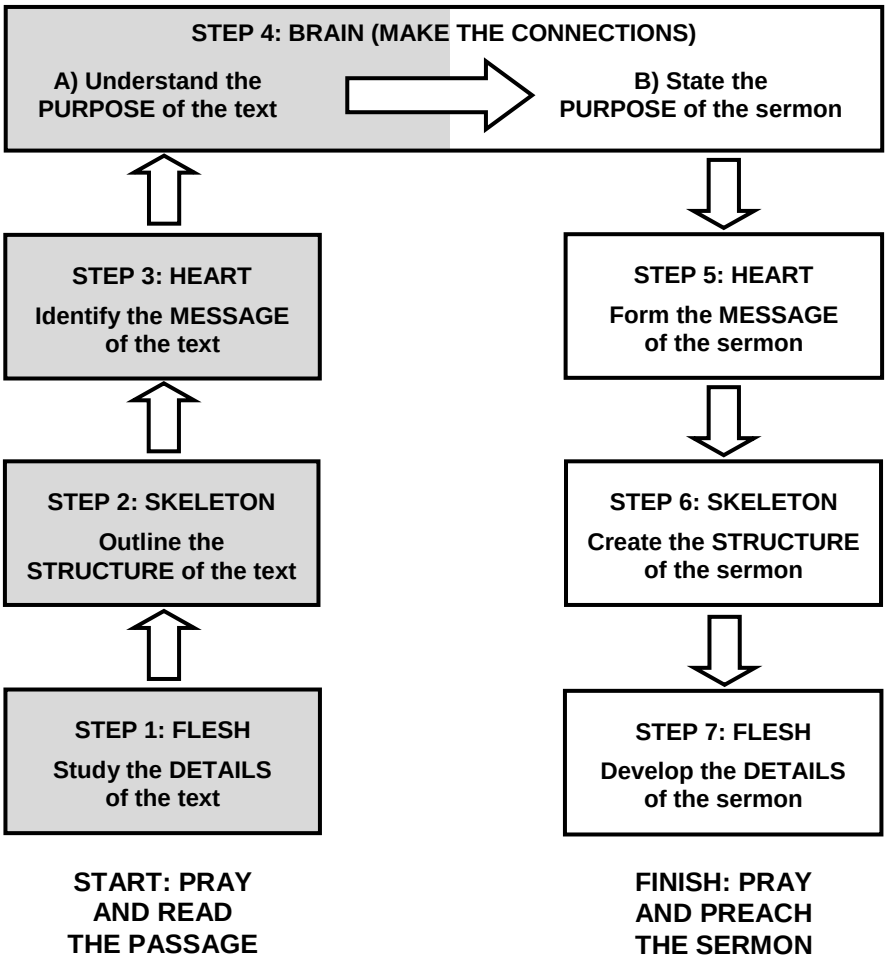
3.3.1 Recalling the Seven Steps of Scripture Sculpture

Recall the *Seven Steps of Scripture Sculpture,* which take you from a passage of Scripture to the message of a sermon, and **explain** them to a fellow participant.

*As a trainer remind the participants about scripture sculpture. Remind them that: We study the **flesh (step 1)** of the text, the detail of the passage in front of us. The more we study the flesh the more we begin to see the **skeleton (step 2)**, the structure of the passage appear. And the more we continue to study the passage the more we get to the **heart (step 3)** of it, the central message. Finally we grasp, or are gripped by the **brain (step 4)** of the text, the purpose the original author had in mind.*

*That brain or purpose will help us develop a **brain (step 4)** or purpose for our preaching. Remember, never preach unless you know why you are preaching. And we can then go on to develop the **heart (step 5)** of our sermon, based on the heart of the passage applied to our people today. The passage may lead to a natural **skeleton (step 6)** or structure for the teaching, or, as our culture and context is different, we may need to develop our own structure to convey the message. Finally we can develop the **flesh (step 7)** of the sermon, the details we will use to preach the message: the illustrations, applications, words and phrases.*

The Seven Steps of Scripture Sculpture:



Remember that the first four steps of Scripture Sculpture, shaded in grey, became the *Four Steps of Encountering a Bible Passage*. They help us discover the original message and purpose of a passage, its heart and brain.

Those four steps of encountering a Bible passage remain the same for any type of Biblical material. Here they are again, each with a reminder of the outcome of each step, and the smaller steps involved.

The Four Steps of Encountering a Bible Passage:

STEP 1: FLESH – Study the DETAILS of the text At the end of this step you will know and understand the key components of the passage. You need to: a) Set the text in **context** b) See the **details** c) Seek the **meaning** d) Summarise the **findings**
STEP 2: SKELETON – Outline the STRUCTURE of the text At the end of this step you will be able to sketch out the structure of the passage and see how the author makes his point. You need to: a) Note all the **bones** in the structure b) Decide on the '**big bones**' and make an **outline** of the structure
STEP 3: HEART – Identify the MESSAGE of the text At the end of this step you will be able to write out the author's main point in one or two sentences. You need to: a) State the **theme** of the passage b) State the **message** of the passage
STEP 4: BRAIN – Understand the PURPOSE of the text At the end of this step you will be able to explain the purpose of the passage and will begin to make connections for teaching it today. You need to: a) State the **purpose** of the passage b) Make **connections** for teaching today

3.3.2 STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text

We will now adapt each step and apply them to Genesis 12:10-20.

At the end of this step you will be familiar with the key components of the passage as you **set** the text in context, **see** the details, **seek** the meaning and **summarise** the findings.

a) Set the text in context

Remember, before we look at any individual Bible passage we need to look at the book as a whole. That means keeping our general discoveries from the previous unit in mind, particularly those from Steps 1 and 2, the context and content of the book (see below).

Encountering a book of the Bible:

Step 1: Establish the original CONTEXT of the book
- Where does the book fit in the Bible's **story**?
- What **situation** was the book was written for?
- What **style** of writing was it written in?

Step 2: Discover the CONTENT of the book
- What is the **structure** of the book?
- What are the main **themes** of the book?
- What is the **message** of the book?
- What is the **purpose** of the book?

In order to set our passage in that context, remember those same three words: **story**, **situation** and **style**.

Look at Genesis 12:10-20 in your Bible and your Trainer will guide you through the relevant points below.

You can make notes in the blank spaces as we go along, and then make a summary in the blank worksheet for Step 1, which can be found in Section 3.5 below.

Story
We need to think about the passage in relation to where it comes in the Bible and in the book:

- How does Genesis 12:10-20 fit into the book of Genesis as a whole?

The completed worksheet highlights these points: Gen 12:1-9 comes before 12:10-20 and introduces God's great promises, Abraham's call and obedience of faith, the marking out of the land, and key characters in the story, including Sarai and Lot (11.27-32 introduces others, including Nahor and Milkah). Gen. 13:1-18 follows, it picks up the theme of Abram's wealth, his generosity to Lot, the Lord's focus on Abram with the

departure of Lot, and the restatement of the promises. Note the golden threads in all these sections (place, people, presence and purpose).

- Do you notice any ways in which the passage links with the story of the Old Testament and the story of the Bible? Remember the framework for understanding God's plan of Salvation that we learnt in Unit 2.

Help the participants to see how this short episode (Abraham's adventures in Egypt) contributes to the story of Abraham (God's promises being fleshed out) and to the story of Genesis (God's promises being fulfilled through a family that is set apart and saved). That story contributes to the story of the Pentateuch, which contributes to the story of the Old Testament, which contributes to the story of the Bible. It anticipates the Exodus story and looks forward to the God who will keep all his promises in Christ.

Situation
We need to think about ways in which this passage from Genesis might connect with the original context:

- Are there any links with situation of God's people and the world they lived in?

God's people are surrounded by other peoples and nations, with their own different views about God or gods, humanity and the world. This presents various challenges and threats to their faith. This and other passages is written into that context.

Style
We need to remember the style of writing:

- What sort of writing is this passage and what does that tell us about the way we should read it?

Story or narrative, as we have already discussed. Remember those six things to know about narrative: (1) audience, (2) narrator, (3) plot, (4) characters, (5) scenes (6) message, explained again below.

See too the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

b) See the details of the text

We have already begun to notice some of the details; we will now highlight the most important ones.

To do this we will **look** for the important details, **highlight** them on the passage, and **list** them in the worksheet.

Look
As you read the passage, **look** for:

1. **Repeated** and **related** words and phrases

2. **Important**, **complicated** and **unusual** words and phrases

3. **Connections** and **links** between the words and phrases

Remember to do this from two perspectives**:**

First, the key themes of Genesis
As you listen and look at a passage note the words and phrases that link the passage with the themes and purpose of the book as a whole. Use the work you did in Step 1 and tie it to specific details in the passage.

Second, the main type of writing, which is story
Because of the nature of stories you need to do this **from the perspective of the 6 features of stories** that we have already noticed.

1. The audience
Think about how this story connects with the audience it is intended for.

2. The narrator
Look out for his selection and repetition of words. Indicators of his perspective and God's perspective.

3. The scenes
These will relate particularly to the structure, or skeleton of the passage, but they also frame the content.

4. The characters
Listing the characters is an important part of seeing the details. Note their words, the dialogue.

5. The plot
Look for signs of how the plot is developing, these are important details.

6. The message
This applies more to the heart and brain of the text, but begin to look for details that might point to it.

Guide the Participants. For example:

The narrator: *In Genesis 12:10-20 the narrator is mainly telling the story from the perspective of Abram, and God's perspective is particularly given in the words of v. 17: "But the LORD inflicted serious diseases..."*

The scenes: *For example, Abram and Sarai in Scene 1 of Gen 12:10-20 – and Abram's unclear morality in the decision he shares with his wife. Abram and Pharaoh take centre stage in Scene 2 – with the tension and suspense created by Abram's decision. In Scene 3 the Lord, the hero, intervenes, which leads to the conflict between Pharaoh and Abram.*

NOTE: LISTEN to the text being read out loud
These stories were originally read out loud. LISTEN to them as well as looking at them. Note what you hear with your ears as well as what you see with your eyes. This will also help you to teach oral learners. Note any features they mention and read them back to them. This will facilitate your learning as much as theirs.

Highlight
Module One encouraged us to mark and **highlight** the passage to help us see with our eyes what we hear with our ears. It improves our powers of observation and helps with learning and teaching.

The passage we are looking at now is given in the worksheet below (Section 3.4). This is how it might appear in your Bible. Your Trainer will demonstrate how you can write, underline, divide up the passage and draw on the text to highlight the important details we are beginning to notice. Be creative and use different shapes and colours if you can.

Green, red, and blue are the most common colours available for black boards or whiteboards. If you do have these colours, use BUILD's simple 'grass, earth and sky' system. Think of them in relation to the **green** of the grass (which covers the land), the **red** of the soil (that is so important for life) and the **blue** of the sky (that connects everything together).

Mark the passage as follows:

1. For **repeated** or **related** words and phrases use **green**

2. For other **important** or **unusual** words and phrases use **red**

3. For **connections** between the words and phrases use **blue**

You can use **black** (or **white** on a chalk board) for more general underlining, notes and structural divisions.

But remember, **be selective** - if you mark everything you have marked nothing!

Go ahead and mark up the passage now.

NOTE: Stories, or episodes of stories, are often long units to study. This means that it is harder to write them on a board, but a passage can be simply photocopied for participants, or broken up into a number of slides to project if you have the technology. Remember that stories were read out loud. This problem of length gives an opportunity to emphasise and use the oral nature of the stories.

List
Once you have marked the passage, list the important words and phrases in the worksheet for Step 1 (go to Section 3.5 below).

See the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

c) Seek the meaning from the details

To seek the meaning of the details you have noticed and listed, begin to ask and answer questions:

- What do these words and phrases mean today in your language?
- What did they mean in the context of the Bible when it was written?
- What is the significance of any relationships and links between the words?

- Review your answers – are they simple, true and consistent in the context of the book, the group of books and the Bible?

Record your observations in the worksheet. Your Trainer will guide you through this.

See the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

d) Summarise the findings

Draw on all the above. What are the main things you have discovered, the most important ideas that you want to carry forward? Make some notes below, but create a summary in the worksheet in 3.5.

See the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

3.3.3 STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text

At the end of this step you will be able to sketch out the structure of the story and see how the narrator makes his point.

a) Note all the bones in the structure

You are aiming to discover the structure the narrator is using – the scenes and the way they are constructed. This is very different to reading a letter where the ideas and logic are so important.

See the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure

There are major parts of the structure and minor ones: big bones and small bones – the main scenes and supporting structures and the smaller components.

With a story the scenes and structure serve the plot, which is wrapped into this. That plot in turn helps support the message. So as you look at the structure, note the plot.

In Gen 12:10-20 the setting is there in v. 10, the problem or tension is there in 11-13, and heightened (rather than resolved) in 14-16, and resolved, dramatically, in 17-19, with the outcome in v. 20 – they are expelled from Egypt.

See the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

3.3.4 STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text

At the end of this step you will be able to write out the author's main point in a sentence or two.

Remember, the Bible is 'God preaching' to his people. Therefore a biblical message is more than just information; it tells us something important and practical about that information.

A simple way of identifying the message of a passage is to note what the author's theme is and to note what he is saying about that theme.

a) State the theme of the passage

Take time and care to reflect on and pray over your discoveries so far and try and capture the theme as simply and as clearly as you can. What is the main thing the author is talking about?

See the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

b) State the message of the passage

Think about this theme and answer this question: What is the author saying about this theme?

Remember, you are aiming to discover the original meaning of a text. Therefore you need to state the message to the original listeners by completing a sentence that begins like this: "The narrator wants his listeners to conclude that..."

See the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

3.3.5 STEP 4: BRAIN – understand the PURPOSE of the text...

At the end of this step you will be able to explain the purpose of the passage and will have made some connections so that you can teach it today.

a) State the purpose of the passage.

Keeping in mind the context of the passage and the book you need to answer the question, Why is the author making this point?

See the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

b) Make connections for teaching today.

The aim of the first four steps of Scripture Sculpture is to discover the original meaning of the passage.

However, the real aim of encountering a passage of Scripture is to apply it to our lives and ministries and to experience its transforming power. We want to discover the significance of the passage for us today.

We must keep in mind not only where the passage belongs in its original context, but also where it belongs in our hearts and lives, in our congregations and communities.

The message statement, **what** is being said, is important as we make connections today. The purpose statement, **why** it is being said is also important.

Think about **what** you and your people need to hear from this Bible passage and **why** they need to hear it.

Capture that in the form of a statement or a question that makes some connections with your situation and your congregation's situation today.

See the completed worksheet and use that to guide your participants.

3.4 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING GENESIS 12:10-20 (THE PASSAGE)

10 Now there was a famine in the land,
and Abram went down to Egypt to live
there for a while because the famine was
severe. 11 As he was about to enter Egypt,
he said to his wife Sarai, ‘I know what a
beautiful woman you are. 12 When the
Egyptians see you, they will say, “This is
his wife.” Then they will kill me but will let
you live. 13 Say you are my sister, so that I
will be treated well for your sake and my
life will be spared because of you.’
14 When Abram came to Egypt, the
Egyptians saw that Sarai was a very
beautiful woman. 15 And when Pharaoh’s
officials saw her, they praised her to
Pharaoh, and she was taken into his
palace. 16 He treated Abram well for her
sake, and Abram acquired sheep and
cattle, male and female donkeys, male and
female servants, and camels.
17 But the Lord inflicted serious diseases
on Pharaoh and his household because of
Abram’s wife Sarai. 18 So Pharaoh
summoned Abram. ‘What have you done
to me?’ he said. ‘Why didn’t you tell me she
was your wife? 19 Why did you say, “She is
my sister,” so that I took her to be my wife?
Now then, here is your wife. Take her and
go!’ 20 Then Pharaoh gave orders about
Abram to his men, and they sent him on
his way, with his wife and everything he
had. (NIV)

3.5 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING GENESIS 12:10-20 – STEP 1

STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text

a) Set the passage in context. How does the passage relate to the book as a whole?

Gen 12:1-9 comes before 12:10-20 and introduces God's great promises, Abraham's call and obedience of faith, the marking out of the land, and key characters in the story, including Sarai and Lot (11.27-32 introduces others, including Nahor and Milkah).

Gen. 13:1-18 follows, it picks up the theme of Abram's wealth, his generosity to Lot, the Lord's focus on Abram with the departure of Lot, and the restatement of the promises. Note the golden threads in all these sections (place, people, presence and purpose).

b) See the details of the text. List important words, phrases, and relationships:	**c) Seek the meaning from the details** Explain important words, phrases, and relationships:
famine x2 (v. 10)	*Threat to the promises. Joseph story preview*
Abram (directly) x6 (v. 10, 14, 16, 17, 18)	*Abram as a key character*
he, his (Abram indirectly, multiple times)	*Abram mentioned indirectly throughout*
Sarai (directly) x3 (v. 11, 14, 17)	*Sarai as a key character*
she, her (Sarai indirectly, multiple times)	*Sarai mentioned indirectly throughout*
beautiful woman x2 (v. 11, 14)	*A description to create tension*
Egypt x2 (v. 10, 11)	*The place (the nations, story of salvation)*
Egyptians x2 (v. 12, 14)	*This all links to the Exodus story*
wife x6 (v. 12, 17, 18, 19, 20)	*Wife rather than sister deceit. Abram trusting*
sister x2 (v. 13, 19)	*his own wisdom rather than in God*
Pharaoh's officials, his men (v. 15, 20)	*Those under the King of Egypt*
Pharaoh x4 (v. 15, 17, 18)	*The King of Egypt. Looks ahead to Exodus*
sheep and cattle (etc) (v. 16)	*Presence of God, blessings as prosperity*
everything he had (v. 20)	*Sent on his way with even more wealth*
land (v. 10)	*The promises: importance of God's place*
they will kill me (v. 12)	*Abram's fear rather than faith*
Lord (v. 17)	*The hero of the story*
serious diseases (v. 17)	*Exodus preview*
go! (v. 19)	*God's intervention through Pharaoh, a preview of Exodus*
Now (v. 10), When (v. 14), But (v. 17)	*Key links in structuring the story*
So (v. 18), Then (v. 20)	*Minor links in structuring the story*

d) Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?

God keeps his promises to Abram and his people, despite the fears and threats. That includes God sparing his people despite famine.

Abram's fear is greater than his faith as he learns to trust God.

God intervenes in a direct and dramatic way.

The story looks ahead to the stories of Joseph, Egypt and the Exodus.

The story ends with Abram being blessed despite a lack of faith.

3.6 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING GENESIS 12:10-20 – STEPS 2 TO 4

STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text

a) Note all the bones in the structure. What elements highlight the structure?

The three main scenes give a structure, marked out by Now (v. 10), When (v. 14), But (v. 17)

These are also marked out by the characters who are involved (Abram and Sarai vv. 10-13; Abram, Pharaoh (and Sarai) vv. 14-16; the Lord, Pharaoh, Abram (and Sarai) vv. 17-20).

So (v. 18) and Then (v. 20) provide minor bones.

The various speeches also provide structure (e.g. vv. 11-13; vv. 18-19)

b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure. What are the most important parts of the structure? Can you describe the main sections?

v. 10 Setting: The promises under threat

vv. 11-13 Abram's fears and lack of faith

vv. 14-16 Abram's deceit leads to undeserved blessing

vv. 17-19 God's action and Pharaoh's reaction

v. 20 Outcome: God protects his promises, and blesses Abram

STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text

a) State the theme of the passage. What is the author's main point?

God is keeping his promises despite Abram's fears and failings.

b) Explain the message of the passage. What is the author saying about his theme?

The message to Israel is that God is faithful to his promises to his people and is in control of history (all in the setting of Egypt and therefore looking forward to a greater exodus).

STEP 4: BRAIN – understand the PURPOSE of the text...

a) State the purpose of the passage. Why is the author making his point?

To encourage God's people, build their faith – helping them to trust his wisdom and faithfulness rather than their own resources.

b) Make connections for teaching today. What is the relevance of this for us?

Our God is the very same God who works to fulfil his plans. He does so despite fearful people who he continues to bless and to shape. The Lord acts directly in history for his name's sake, pointing to his greatest deliverance in Jesus Christ.

3.7 RESPONDING TO THE MESSAGE OF GENESIS 12:10-20

In Unit 7 we will consider how we can adapt the steps of preparing a sermon that we learnt in Unit 13 of Module One to preaching from Old Testament stories.

But it is important for us to respond to the message we have discovered in Genesis 12:10-20. Here are three simple questions that will help us to do that:

1. In what ways does the theme and the message of the passage speak to you personally?

2. How does the purpose and the relevance of the passage reinforce God's word to you?

3. Do you now have an important message that you want to share with other people? State and explain that message using your own words.

Unit 4. Genesis 1:1-2:3 (Encounter)

Overview

Every module has a number of opportunities for you to be coached in your ability to handle the Bible. This unit applies the lessons of Unit 3 to Genesis 1:1-2:3.

Outline

- Introduction
- Worksheet for the passage
- Worksheet for Step 1
- Worksheet for Steps 2 to 4
- Responding to the message of Genesis 1:1-2:3

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Follow and apply the four steps of Encountering a Bible Story to a passage from Genesis yourself
2. Share the message of Genesis 1:1-2:3 with a group of people today
3. Make some connections for teaching that passage today

Give the Participants an opportunity to apply the steps themselves, individually or in groups. You might want to take the whole group, interactively, through one or more stages in order to vary the approach. Or you might vary the group sizes: they could 'see the details' individually, 'seek the meaning' in groups and 'summarise the findings' with your help as the whole group.

4.1 INTRODUCTION

This unit applies the learning from Unit 3 to Genesis 1:1-2:3. Keep referring back to the steps you were introduced to. Choose whether to work on your own or in a group.

Spend time reflecting on the text on the following pages. If you are working in a group take it in turns reading it the passage out loud between each step, and listen and look for the relevant things each time the passage is read.

Suggestion: Write out the passage in a notebook and record your observations there. Later on you can mark the text and complete the sheets in this manual, which you will want to keep for reference. You may want to wait until your Trainer takes you through the unit before recording it in this book.

Note: Genesis 1:1-2:3 is a lengthy narrative. Days three, four and five (vv. 9-23) have been left out to keep the text down to two pages. Mark those two pages but look at the whole passage together and note the patterns within it.

4.2 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING GENESIS 1:1-2:3 – THE PASSAGE

1 In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth. **2** Now the earth was formless and empty, darkness was over the surface of the deep, and the Spirit of God was hovering over the waters.

3 And God said, 'Let there be light,' and there was light. **4** God saw that the light was good, and he separated the light from the darkness. **5** God called the light 'day', and the darkness he called 'night'. And there was evening, and there was morning – the first day.

6 And God said, 'Let there be a vault between the waters to separate water from water.' **7** So God made the vault and separated the water under the vault from the water above it. And it was so. **8** God called the vault 'sky'. And there was evening, and there was morning – the second day.

Due to the length and richness the passage it continues below at v. 26 (the second creative act of day six). But look at the passage as a whole together, noting the patterns within it.

26 Then God said, 'Let us make mankind in our image, in our likeness, so that they may rule over the fish in the sea and the birds in the sky, over the livestock and all the wild animals, and over all the creatures that move along the ground.'

27 So God created mankind in his own image,
in the image of God he created them;
male and female he created them.

28 God blessed them and said to them, 'Be fruitful and increase in number; fill the earth and subdue it. Rule over the fish in the sea and the birds in the sky and over every living creature that moves on the ground.'
29 Then God said, 'I give you every seed-bearing plant on the face of the whole earth and every tree that has fruit with seed in it. They will be yours for food. 30 And to all the beasts of the earth and all the birds in the sky and all the creatures that move along the ground – everything that has the breath of life in it – I give every green plant for food.' And it was so.
31 God saw all that he had made, and it was very good. And there was evening, and there was morning – the sixth day.

2 Thus the heavens and the earth were completed in all their vast array.

2 By the seventh day God had finished the work he had been doing; so on the seventh day he rested from all his work. 3 Then God blessed the seventh day and made it holy, because on it he rested from all the work of creating that he had done. (NIV)

4.3 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING GENESIS 1:1-2:3 – STEP 1

STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text

a) Set the passage in context. How does the passage relate to the book as a whole?

Style*: story with poetic elements. The foundational story for God's people in contrast with the stories of the other nations. The passage begins and ends with God creating and completing "the heavens and the earth" (1:1, 2:3). 2:4 begins another creation "account".*

Setting*: the passage opens the story of Genesis, which means beginnings. It explains the beginnings of God's world to Israel, within their context of the beliefs of surrounding nations. The beginnings of God's world will be followed by the beginnings of God's people.*

b) See the details of the text. List important words, phrases, and relationships:	**c) Seek the meaning from the details** Explain important words, phrases, and relationships:
God x32 (together with "he" and "his")	*One God behind it all who speaks and acts*
created x5 (1:1, 21, 27), made x6 (1:7 etc)	*God's activity of bringing things into being*
heavens x2 (1:1, 2:1) earth x10 (1:1, 2 etc)	*God's place and man's place*
heavens and earth x2 (1:1, 2:1)	*God's whole universe, seen and unseen*
darkness x4 (1:2, 4, 5, 18)	*Symbol of chaos and evil*
deep, waters x4 (1:2, 6, 10)	*Sea, reinforces the idea of chaos*
said x11 (1:3, 6, 9 etc), let x11 ("Let…" x7)	*God commands and creates*
light x8 (1:3-5, 14-18)	*God's revelation and saving work*
vault x8 (1:6-7, 14-16 etc)	*A divider giving clear separation*
God saw… good x 7 (e.g. 1:4, 10, 12, 18, 21, 25, ending very good in 1:31)	*Whole and perfect, repeated 7 times underlining completion and approval*
separated x2 (1:4, 7)	*Orderly, holy creation*
day/s x14 (1:5, 8, 13, 14-19 etc)	*24hr period (and in contrast to night)*
called x5, blessed x3	*God creates and names and blesses*
Mankind x2 (1:26-27)	*Humanity*
Image, likeness x4 (1:26-27)	*Ruler and representative under God*
rule x2 (1:26, 28)	*Steward and care for in God's place*
food x2 (1:29, 30)	*God sustains people rather than eating them*
rested x2 (2:2, 3)	*A pattern of rest built into creation*
In the beginning (1:1)	*The origins of the world or start of time*
formless and empty (1:2)	*Chaos, disorganisation and emptiness*
Spirit (1:2)	*God's creative Spirit and presence*
stars (1:16)	*Created beings not gods as in pagan thought*
male and female (1:27), "be fruitful and increase in number"	*Sexual difference: men and women together and individually made in God's image*
And, so, then, thus, by	*Key links in structuring the story*

d) Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?

One God not many gods. God creates by his powerful word of command.

All of it is good and is complete.

Mankind is the pinnacle of creation and God's representative ruler.

4.4 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING GENESIS 1:1-2:3 – STEPS 2 TO 4

STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text

a) Note all the bones in the structure. What elements highlight the structure?

"In the beginning" opens the story.

The phrase "the heavens and the earth" (1:1, 2:3) acts as a pair of bookends, with everything in between is about the creation of God's world. (2:4 then begins another creation "account".)

"And God said" repeatedly introduces the acts of creation.

"the first day", "the second day", "the third day" etc – the seven days of creation

b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure. What are the most important parts of the structure? Can you describe the main sections?

1:1-2 The setting of God's work of creation.

1.3-31 God's six stage work of creation:

Day 1. Light and dark (vv. 3-5)
Day 2. Sea and sky (vv. 6-8)
Day 3. Fertile land (vv. 9-13)
Day 4. Lights of day and night (vv. 14-19)
Day 5. Sea and sky creatures (vv. 20-23)
Day 6. Land creatures and mankind (vv. 26-31)

2:1-3 The outcome of God's work of creation - Day 7. Rest.

STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text

a) State the theme of the passage. What is the author's main point?

The whole world was created by one, good, powerful God. Humanity is the pinnacle of God's creation, made to be his representative, caring for creation.

b) Explain the message of the passage. What is the author saying about his theme?

In contrast to the beliefs of the surrounding nations there is only one supreme God rather than many gods. God made the whole world effortlessly and beautifully and is separate from his creation. Mankind was created good and in relation to God.

STEP 4: BRAIN – understand the PURPOSE of the text...

a) State the purpose of the passage. Why is the author making his point?

So that Israel might know who their God is and who they are as a witness to this God. In the context of local deities for different places, Israel's God is creator of the whole earth, doing good to all people and all creation.

b) Make connections for teaching today. What is the relevance of this for us?

In the context of many beliefs we need to know that our God is the one, great, creator God, made to live under his authority and represent him in the world.

4.5 RESPONDING TO THE MESSAGE OF GENESIS 1:1-2:3

Here are three simple exercises to do in response to God's word to us in the passage we have just encountered:

1. Describe how the message you discovered in the passage spoke to you personally: What did you learn or need to be reminded of?

2. Share how the purpose of the passage helped you to apply God's word to your life: What change will this passage make to your thinking and living?

3. State and explain the message you will share with others using your own words: What is the main thing you want people to understand?

Unit 5. God's world and our worldviews (Reflection)

Overview

It is important to consider how people understand the world around them, their 'worldviews', and to compare them with God's authoritative view of his world, which the Bible gives. It will not only help us to clarify our own thinking and faith, but will also help us to share it with others.

Outline

- Introducing worldviews
- Theological reflection revisited
- Encountering the Biblical worldview and our worldviews
- Reflection on God's world and our worldviews
- Action in God's world with the wisdom of God's word

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Explain the meaning of the term 'worldview'
2. List a series of questions that will help us to describe someone's worldview
3. Contrast other people's worldviews with a biblical worldview
4. Use worldview questions to begin the process of sharing the gospel with someone who is not a Christian

5.1 INTRODUCING WORLDVIEWS

Every human being thinks about questions such as these:

- Where did everything come from and how was the world made?
- Is there any purpose to life and the world we live in?
- What is the nature of the invisible world of God and the spirits?
- What is wrong with the world and why is there evil?
- What is the future of the world?

In your groups think about these and other questions and your own local community:

- Are there other questions of life that are important in your local community?

- How do people in your local community answer those questions?

Each person has ideas about the natural and supernatural world around them, "the heavens and the earth" (Gen 1:1). They have their own answers to those questions we began with above, which form a picture of the world in which they live and how it is organised.

These views of the world are called 'worldviews' or, more technically, 'cosmologies'. 'Cosmology' simply means an understanding of the world (from the Greek word, cosmos).

Often whole cultures or groups of people share a common understanding of the world they are a part of.

- Where do these beliefs come from and how are they passed on?

- To what extent are the views of people in one group or culture influenced by those of their neighbours? Compare the beliefs of different ethnic groups in your area (perhaps pick a single belief, for example the origins of life).

- Do you think that people's views are influenced by whether they are in an urban or a rural setting? If they are, why do you think that is the case?

5.2 RECALLING THE 'ERA' REFLECTION CYCLE

We will take a closer look at God's world and our worldviews by recalling and then following the BUILD 'ERA' model of theological reflection or Christian thinking.

5.2.1 The three steps of theological reflection

In Module One we discovered that Christian reflection can be done through a three step process. Those steps encourage us to learn and help us to serve God more faithfully. We called the process the 'ERA' cycle.

- Why did we call the process the 'ERA' cycle?

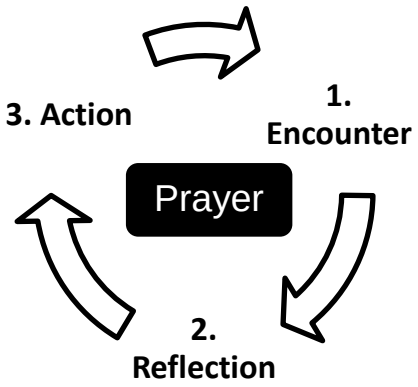
We called the process the 'ERA' cycle because there are three steps to it. Encounter, Reflection, and Action.

- Can you recall the three steps that we learnt?

*The process begins when we **encounter** something in God's world and God's word and a desire to gain wisdom. It continues with **reflection** on those situations and Scriptures in order to gain wisdom. It leads to **action** in God's world with that wisdom from God's word.*

5.2.2 The steps as a cycle

Taking action in God's world always leads to fresh discoveries that deepen our reflection and refine our action. The steps can therefore be understood as a cycle, one with prayer at its heart:



5.2.3 'ERA' is a simple way to remember the steps

The word 'ERA' is a simple way to remember the three steps:

'E' for **Encounter**
'R' for **Reflection**
'A' for **Action**

'ERA' is also a helpful word. It means 'a significant period of time'. For example the reign of a king is known as the era of that king. That is why ERA is a helpful way to remember this cycle: the purpose of Christian reflection and action is to demonstrate a desire that "God's will be done on earth as it is in heaven". In other words, to point to God's Kingdom, the new era he is bringing.

5.2.4 Summary table for the ERA cycle

Step and description	Definition	Activity	Outcome
Encounter something in God's word and God's world	To meet something new and surprising	Describe	Discoveries
Reflection and gaining wisdom from God's word for action in God's world	Pause for thought and go deeper	Question	Principles
Action in God's world with the wisdom of God's word	Do something new or different	Test	Practice
In all this the insight is from the Lord – **prayer** is essential. Pray as David prayed: "Open my eyes that I may see wonderful things in your law" (Psalm 119:18).			

We will now apply these steps to the topic of God's world and our worldviews.

5.3 ENCOUNTERING THE BIBLICAL WORLDVIEW AND OUR WORLDVIEWS

We saw in Unit 4 that Genesis gives God's authoritative account of the world. Genesis aims to shape and define the worldview of God's people who are surrounded by competing worldviews.

5.3.1 Worldview questions

In order to **describe** God's world – his authoritative worldview – and describe other worldviews so that we can reflect further on them, it is helpful to use a set of 'worldview' questions, for example:

1. Is there a God or gods?
2. What is the nature of that God or those gods?
3. Where did the world come from?
4. How does the natural world relate to the supernatural?
5. Where does mankind fit in?
6. What is wrong with the world and what is the solution to this?
7. Why do people die and what happens to them?
8. What is the nature of time?

5.3.2 The biblical worldview in the context of the surrounding nations

Not all these questions are addressed or answered directly by Genesis. But the early chapters deliberately make a comparison between God's description of the world he has made and the ways people in the nations surrounding God's people understand it. We discovered this in Unit 4 and some of these comparisons are made below:

Worldview question	Biblical	Surrounding nations
1. God or gods?	There is only one God	Many gods
2. Nature of God or gods?	God is all knowing, all powerful and caring	Competing and changeable
3. Origin of the world?	Created by God from nothing	It has always been here. 'Creation' reorganises matter
4. Natural and supernatural?	Natural world quite separate from the supernatural world, created by God, but it is sustained by him	Parts of creation (sun, moon, stars, monsters) are supernatural
5. Mankind?	Pinnacle and steward of creation as ruler and representative. Mankind sinful and situation worsening	Afterthought to provide food for the gods. Mankind wise and situation improving
6. Problem and solution?	Human rebellion and God's curse. Judgement and new start (flood)	Overpopulation. Wipe out some of mankind (flood)
7. Death?	Due to God's judgement	Due to the gods reaction

5.3.3 Encountering our own worldviews

In your discussion groups:

- Apply these questions to the worldviews of those around us. We began this process at the beginning of the unit. Now take that discussion further by thinking about the worldviews of local culture and **describe** them:

- If you have time identify some of the features of **global** culture and discuss whether these have influenced **local** worldviews.

Remember that at this stage of reflection we are **describing** things and making **discoveries**.

5.4 REFLECTION ON GOD'S WORLD AND OUR WORLDVIEWS

Build on these discoveries through reflection: Pause for thought and go deeper.

- To what extent are the worldviews and cultural stories of those around us at odds with the true view of the world, which Genesis provides?

- Does a modern 'Western' view of the world, where the supernatural has been squeezed out of the picture (called 'secularism') have an influence on our own worldview and the views of others around us?

- Some elements of local worldviews, for example a belief in a supernatural world, are in agreement with a biblical worldview. But are we guilty of adopting or not rejecting other elements? What are the effects of that?

5.5 ACTION IN GOD'S WORLD WITH THE WISDOM OF GOD'S WORD

> "By faith we understand that the universe was formed at God's command, so that what is seen was not made out of what was visible" (Hebrews 11:1).

This gives us great confidence as Christians in the power of God. Many other aspects of the Biblical worldview also help us in our faith. For example we now know we have nothing to fear from other supernatural powers, which are created beings under God's authority that have been conquered by Christ. They can no longer intimidate us.

But the questions in 5.3.1 and the Biblical worldview expressed in 5.3.2 not only encourage us as Christians but also help us to share our faith with others.

- Discuss how you can use these worldview questions and your understanding of the Biblical worldview to help people to understand and respond to the gospel.

Unit 6. Stewardship and sustainability (Action)

Overview

'Stewardship' is a word that summarises humanity's God given role in his creation. Because the Bible is one big story that central role is explained and developed throughout Scripture. And takes on a new significance in the light of God's mission to the world in and through Jesus Christ.

Outline

- Introduction
- Encountering stewardship
- Further reflection on stewardship
- Taking action as God's stewards for the sake of mission

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Explain the nature of stewardship and why it is so important
2. Give a Christian account of the words and ideas that people use in community development
3. Create a team that can plan and implement community mission

6.1 INTRODUCTION

- What did we discover about the role of humanity when we encountered Genesis 1:1–2:3 in Unit 4?

In Genesis 1:1–2:3 we discovered that mankind is **God's representative**: his ruler under his authority. That is at the heart of what it means to be made in God's image.

Genesis 2:4-25 gives a second "account of the heavens and the earth when they were created".

- Read through Genesis 2:4-25.

Genesis 2:15 goes on to underline that role:

> "The Lord God took the man and put him in the Garden of Eden to work it and take care of it."

God continues to sustain and care for his world but the care of creation is also delegated to mankind.

In your discussions in Unit 4 you will almost certainly have used the word 'stewardship'. We will think more about stewardship in this unit so that we can take action.

6.2 ENCOUNTERING STEWARDSHIP

Remember, 'encounter', our first step in our process of reflection, is about describing things and discovering things. We will begin with that as we describe and discover things about stewardship in God's word and God's world.

- Are there other passages you can think of in the Old Testament or New Testament that address the idea of stewardship? What are they?

  Luke has a number of parables that speak to the theme of stewardship. You could focus on one or more of these: Luke 12:42-46; 16:1-15; 19:11-27.

- Consider one or two of those passages and produce a definition of the term 'stewardship'.

- Now think about your church and local community: is your church an effective steward of the resources it has been given? Is your community an effective steward of its resources?

These questions should make you think further. They might lead you to repent: for your own poor stewardship; and/or for the lack of stewardship in your church or churches; and/or to repent on behalf of those around you.

6.3 FURTHER REFLECTION ON STEWARDSHIP

'Reflection' means pausing for thought and going deeper. It means questioning things and developing biblical principles. We will do this very simply by thinking about how these words and ideas are connected:

Stewardship

Sustainability

Creation care

Resource mobilisation

Microfinance

Income generation

Livelihood support

Christian mission

- Some of these are ‘buzz words’ that NGOs and others use and that we talk about often, particularly when thinking about ‘community development’. What does each word or term mean? What are the links between them? Scatter them on a sheet of paper in a similar way to the way they have been arranged above. Draw and describe the way they might relate to one another.

- Are there other important words you would add? Are there scriptures you can put by any of these words and ideas?

- What principles are emerging from this exercise?

6.4 TAKING ACTION AS GOD’S STEWARDS FOR THE SAKE OF MISSION

Give time to thinking through specific steps that you can use to lead your church in mission in the area of stewardship.

Here are some steps that one BUILD group came up with. Discuss them, modify them for your situation and begin to put them into practice:

1. Form a team. Remember a church is a team. Or create a team within the fellowship. Beware creating a committee that simply discusses things and creates paperwork. Prayer and scripture study will be an important part of the work of this team.

2. Map the village or area. Imagine what it would be like looking down on your village or area (imagine you are a bird flying over it). Use a simple diagram with basic symbols to answer these questions: What different resources are there and where are they? What are the problem places where there are needs?

3. Identify simple needs. Identify simple needs that can be addressed with the resources you have identified.

4. Prayerfully decide on a small ‘seed’ project. Pray and discuss together and see if there is a simple seed project that will address this particular need in a way that will point to the Kingdom of God and its values.

5. Plan steps to develop and implement the simple project. Capture all the above in some basic steps which will guide you as you take action. Remember to have a clear aim and set of steps to take. Remember to note the resources you will need. Put a time frame on it.

Unit 7. Genesis 11:1-9 (Encounter)

Overview

This unit applies the lessons of Unit 3 to Genesis 11:1-9, a process we have practiced in Unit 4. In addition it looks at how to preach from Genesis and the Pentateuch, particularly the stories contained in those books.

Outline

- Worksheet for Encountering Genesis 11:1-9 – The passage
- Worksheet for Encountering Genesis 11:1-9 (Step 1)
- Worksheet for Encountering Genesis 11:1-9 (Steps 2-4)
- Responding to the message of Genesis 11:1-9
- Preaching from Genesis and the Pentateuch

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Follow and apply the four steps of Encountering a Bible passage to a passage from Genesis and the Pentateuch yourself
2. Share the message of Genesis 11:1-9with a group of people today

As with previous units that encounter Bible passages, give the participants an opportunity to apply the steps for themselves and help them with the process.

NOTE: You will see from the overview, above, that this unit covers a fair amount of ground. It not only encounters a passage from Genesis, which is on the next sheet, but it also looks at how to preach from Genesis and the Pentateuch.

But the story is well known and is a good length. Read the passage through and use the space below to give some of your initial reactions to it in the light of what we have learned about the story of Genesis and the Pentateuch and how it relates to the Bible as a whole. Use these questions to guide your thoughts and discussions:

- What new things are you now seeing in this well-known story?

- How might you preach it differently, now that you understand more clearly how Genesis fits into the story of the Pentateuch, and into the Bible as a whole?

7.1 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING GENESIS 11:1-9 – THE PASSAGE

11 Now the whole world had one language
and a common speech. **2** As people moved
eastward, they found a plain in Shinar and
settled there.
3 They said to each other, 'Come, let's
make bricks and bake them thoroughly.'
They used brick instead of stone, and
bitumen for mortar. **4** Then they said,
'Come, let us build ourselves a city, with a
tower that reaches to the heavens, so that
we may make a name for ourselves;
otherwise we will be scattered over the
face of the whole earth.'
5 But the Lord came down to see the city
and the tower the people were
building. **6** The Lord said, 'If as one people
speaking the same language they have
begun to do this, then nothing they plan to
do will be impossible for them. **7** Come, let
us go down and confuse their language so
they will not understand each other.'
8 So the Lord scattered them from there
over all the earth, and they stopped
building the city. **9** That is why it was called
Babel – because there the Lord confused
the language of the whole world. From
there the Lord scattered them over the
face of the whole earth. (NIV)

7.2 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING GENESIS 11:1-9 – STEP 1

STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text

a) Set the passage in context. How does the passage relate to the book as a whole?

*In the **story** of Genesis this forms the conclusion to the account of Noah and his family that began with a description of sin and evil (6:1-8). It describes the deep rooted nature of human sin. The story of Noah explored one incomplete answer to that problem. Babel explores another answer, which again only partly deals with the problem.*

11:1-9 leads into the family record of Shem to Terah, Abram's father (vv. 10-26). This leads to the story of Abram's family (vv. 27-32). This provides the background to 12:1-9 and God's new beginning for mankind.

b) See the details of the text.	**c) Seek the meaning from the details**
List important words, phrases, and relationships:	Explain important words, phrases, and relationships:
whole world, whole earth x3 (v. 1, 4, 9)	*Complete unity and then complete confusion*
people (directly) x3 (v. 2, 5, 6)	*Emphasis on humanity in contrast to God*
(people indirectly multiple times - "they" etc)	*(as above)*
language, speech x5 (v. 1, 7, 9)	*Emphasis on the power of language*
one, common, same x4 (v. 1, 6)	*Mankind united against God*
Come x3 (v. 3, 4, 7)	*Planning – people's plans; God's plans*
brick, bitumen x3 (v. 3)	*Building materials*
build, building x3 (v. 4, 5, 8)	*The activity of building upwards*
city, tower x5 (v. 4, 5, 8)	*The outcome of building*
scattered x 3 (v. 4, 8, 9)	*God's act of judgement as separation*
the Lord x 5 (v. 5, 6, 8, 9)	*God's repeated involvement as King*
settled (v. 2)	*Society developing separate from God*
eastwards (v. 2)	*Picture of judgement – east of Eden (3:24)*
But the Lord came down (v. 5)	*God acts and man's smallness (Isa 40:22)*
If as one people…	*Human effort to be like God*
Babel (v. 9)	*Babylon is under judgment, it is confused*
Now, As, Then, But, So, That	*Connecting words moving the story forwards*
That is why…	*The explanation that is the point of the story*

d) Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?

Babel was meant to be a symbol of human effort but it became a sign of God's judgement.

Humanity attempts to take God's place – sin is portrayed as God's representative wanting to become ruler.

Part of the ongoing cycle of judgement and grace.

In Scripture this is an open attack on Babylon, which is a picture of human pride.

7.3 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING GENESIS 11:1-9 – STEPS 2 TO 4

STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text

a) Note all the bones in the structure. What elements highlight the structure?

The "whole world" (v. 1) and "whole earth" (v. 9) provide the introduction and conclusion.
"But the Lord came down" is the centre piece and turning point of the story.
On each side of that intervention people are "settled" (v. 2) but then "scattered" (v. 8).
People's plans ("let us" v. 3-4) contrast with God's plans ("let us" v. 6-7).
The story is shaped by connecting words: "Now", "As", "Then", "But", "So", "That" etc.

b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure. What are the most important parts of the structure? Can you describe the main sections?

Setting: "the whole world… one language" (v. 1)
People "settled" (v. 2)
<u>People's plans - "Come, let us" (v. 3-4)</u>
God's intervention "But the Lord came down" (v. 5)
<u>God's plans - "Come, let us" (v. 6-7)</u>
People "scattered" (v. 8)
Outcome: "confused the language… the whole earth" (v. 9)

STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text

a) State the theme of the passage. What is the author's main point?

Mankind is united against God in their sinful pride, which God judges and condemns.

b) Explain the message of the passage. What is the author saying about his theme?

God is the all-powerful ruler who will stand against and discipline sinful mankind.

STEP 4: BRAIN – understand the PURPOSE of the text...

a) State the purpose of the passage. Why is the author making his point?

To provide the background to God's story of salvation, and to explain the meaning and significance of Babel (and Babylon) as humanity in opposition to God. To show that the variety of peoples, languages and nations in God's world are a sign of God's judgement on humanity.

b) Make connections for teaching today. What is the relevance of this for us?

Sinful humanity continues to set himself up against God with our latest projects. God has revealed himself to be a King of judgement and grace, overturning our efforts with his work of salvation in Jesus Christ.

Pentecost begins to reverse the confusion, with one people, understanding and sharing one gospel, by one Spirit (as Zephaniah 3:9 predicted). God's people are to demonstrate that now.

7.4 RESPONDING TO THE MESSAGE OF GENESIS 11:1-9

In 7.5, below, we will think through how the steps of preparing a sermon that we learnt in Module One apply to preaching from Genesis and Old Testament stories generally, and to Genesis 11:1-9 specifically.

But before we do so we will respond to the message of Genesis 11:1-9 at a more basic level, by using the three questions we have used before, questions that apply the discoveries we have made in the steps of encountering that passage.

These questions consider the theme, message and purpose of the passage and how they apply to us today, as well as how we can share that message with others.

They therefore form a bridge, which will then help us to think about preaching from this type of biblical material. Here are the three questions:

1. Describe how the message you discovered in the passage spoke to you personally: What did you learn or need to be reminded of?

2. Share how the purpose of the passage helped you to apply God's word to your life: What change will this passage make to your thinking and living?

3. State and explain the message you will share with others using your own words: What is the main thing you want people to understand?

7.5 PREACHING FROM GENESIS AND THE PENTATEUCH

We have encountered and responded to a few different passages from the book of Genesis. We will now build on that and think through how we can preach from Genesis and the Pentateuch, particularly the stories contained in those books.

Remember, the steps we have followed in encountering a Bible passage form the first half of a process called 'Scripture Sculpture', a process that takes us from reading a Bible passage to preaching that passage. In order to think through how we can preach from Genesis and the Pentateuch we will do three things:

First, we will first remember all seven steps in the 'Scripture Sculpture' process, so that we can see how it all joins together.

Secondly, we will think through how what we have already learnt about Genesis and the Pentateuch in the first few units of this module impact the way in which we preach from these books. In other words how we should approach the final steps in the process.

Finally, we will apply these lessons to Genesis 11:1-9 and produce the key components for a sermon on that passage.

7.5.1 Remembering the seven steps of the Scripture Sculpture process

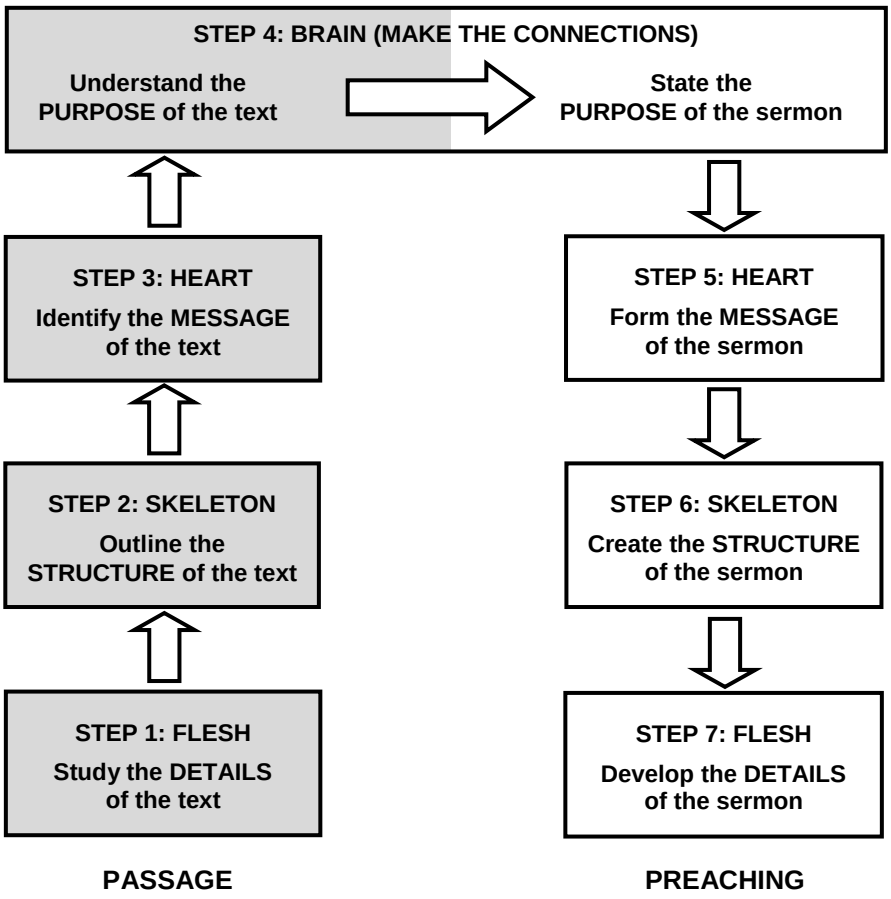
In the seven steps of the Scripture Sculpture process, below, we have gone up the left hand side of the diagram:

> We have studied the details of the text and become familiar with its 'flesh'.
>
> We have outlined the structure of the text and have seen its 'bones'.
>
> We have identified the message of the text and got to its 'heart'.
>
> Finally, we have understood the purpose of the text, and seen the 'brain' behind it.

That last step is part of a bridge that leads into the right hand side, where the focus is on preparing the sermon or talk; we began to think about the connections with our world and our churches today.

The next stage is to think through how to build on all this work, beginning with a clear purpose statement for the sermon. Then, using the observations from our work on the passage we need to create a 'heart', a 'skeleton', and finally some 'flesh' for our teaching.

Here is that Scripture Sculpture diagram, again, so you can see what has been done already (in grey), and what needs to be done as we develop a sermon (in white):



This means we will be focussing on the second part of Step 4 and then on steps 5 to 7. Those steps are summarised below in a table taken from Unit 13 of Module One. Look back at that unit for more guidance if you need to.

Completing the Scripture Sculpture process:

STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon

At the end of this step you will be able to state and explain the purpose of the sermon. You need to:

a) Keep your **listeners** in mind
b) Decide what God wants your people to **understand and obey**
c) State the **purpose** of the sermon

STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon

At the end of this step you will be able to state and explain the message of the sermon in one or two sentences. You need to:

a) State the **theme** of your sermon
b) Build on that and state the **message** of your sermon
c) **Check** that the message 'works' for your people today

STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon

At the end of this step you will have a clear outline for the sermon. You need to:

a) Clarify the **main points** or structure of the sermon
b) Create an **introduction**
c) Develop the **body**
d) Have an idea for the **conclusion**

STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon

At the end of this step you can preach the sermon to your people. You need to:

a) Remember the importance of **words**
b) Create **notes** that will help you to preach
c) Use your **voice** to communicate
d) Take care with **presentation**
e) Remember the importance of **evaluation**

Keep these steps in mind as you study the sections below about Mark and the gospels. We will take these steps above and use them as a worksheet for preparing sermon outlines throughout the module.

7.5.2 How to preach from Genesis and the Pentateuch

The first three units of the module covered a great deal of ground, all of which is important when it comes to preaching from these books. In Unit 1 we looked at the Pentateuch and the Bible's story, which put the books in the context of the whole story of the Bible. We then, in Unit 2, looked in more detail at that story and the different threads and stages in it – we saw the important role these books play in providing a foundation for the story. Finally, in Unit 3, we had a closer look at individual Bible stories and how they work.

This section on 'How to preach from Genesis and the Pentateuch' looks at those three units and applies some of the ideas in them to preaching from the books. It cannot cover everything. As you move through the module and think about preaching different passages, look back through those units and think for yourself how the ideas we have covered affect how we preach from these books.

Ideas on how to preach from Unit 1, 'The Pentateuch and the Bible's story'
In Unit 1 we learnt about the importance of story and the Bible's story. The Bible may have many stories, but they are all part of one story, the unfolding story of God's world and his new world. We also saw the importance of linking that story to our stories.

- When we are preaching from Genesis and the Pentateuch, we need to demonstrate how the story or section we are looking at links to the story as a whole, so that we not only help people to make sense of the story we are looking at, but also enrich their understanding of the Bible as a whole.

- When we are preaching from Genesis and the Pentateuch, we need to help people to see how their lives link to God's story and how they are caught up in it, not least as a part of God's people today.

Ideas on how to preach from Unit 2, Genesis 12:1-9 and God's plan of salvation
In Unit 2 we learnt some foundational truths about the **context** for understanding passages from Genesis and the Pentateuch. For example, we noted the **situation** of God's people, living in the midst of other cultures, religions and worldviews and the need for them to have a distinctive view of what it means to be God's people. Those truths feed into the message and purpose of the books. We also explored the **story** aspect further: we saw the threads that run through the whole story, and which hold it together. And we noted the various stages in the story.

- When we are preaching from Genesis and the Pentateuch, we can make connections between the pressures God's people faced then, surrounded by the nations but called to live as a light to the nations, and the pressures we face today.

- When we are preaching from Genesis and the Pentateuch, we can use the details of how God's story unfolds, both in the threads that run through it and the stages it follows, to give people a clearer understanding of how the story or passage we are looking at fits in, and to show how it links with our lives, as part of God's people today.

- When we are preaching from Genesis and the Pentateuch, we need to use the structure of the Bible that we have discovered (the threads and the stages), to lead people to Jesus and the Gospel. We need to preach our passage from Genesis and the Pentateuch, as part of the Christian Bible.

Ideas on how to preach from Unit 3, Bible stories and Genesis 12:10-20
Finally, in Unit 3, we learnt more about how individual stories work. We will look at those and apply them directly.

- When we are preaching from Genesis and the Pentateuch, we need to remember the importance of the **audience** that the story is for. This means we need to keep in mind the context of God's people then and, when preaching, God's people today, we must link what God is saying then to what he is saying now to his people.

- When we are preaching from Genesis and the Pentateuch, we need to remember the significance of the **narrator**, who in Bible stories emphasises God's viewpoint. Keeping that in mind will help people to understand the text and apply it to their lives, as we help them to see what God is saying to them, today.

- When we are preaching from Genesis and the Pentateuch, we need to remember the importance of the **scenes** that the story uses. The scenes, and the episodes too, if we are taking a longer section, structure the action. Stories are gripping, we can use the structure to serve our communication.

- When we are preaching from Genesis and the Pentateuch, we need to remember the centrality of the **characters** that the story focuses on. The characters bring life to the story, we can use that in our communication – when preaching stories we can use the characters as a natural, God-given source of illustration. But remember that God is the greatest character in the story – point to him.

- When we are preaching from Genesis and the Pentateuch, we need to remember the importance of the **plot** that the story develops. The plot or stages of development of the story, helps keep people's attention, use it to keep your people's attention when preaching, and use it to make your point.

- When we are preaching from Genesis and the Pentateuch, we need to remember the ultimate **message** that the story tells. Our 'point' needs to be the point of the passage. The point of a story is not usually stated clearly, we need to discover what it is, which makes it all the more powerful. When we are preaching from a story we need to lead people to make a right conclusion for themselves, and help them to apply that message to their lives. Stories are entertaining, but we need to make sure that they are also educational and life-changing.

7.5.3 Preaching the message of Genesis 11:1-9

Use the table below to outline some of the key ideas in your sermon or talk:

STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon My sermon's purpose statement:
STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon My sermon's theme and its message statement:
STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon My sermon's outline (with the main points, introduction and conclusion):
STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon My sermon's details (note here key words, explanations, illustrations and applications that will help you write notes or a full sermon):

Unit 8. Sin and evil (Reflection)

Overview

Genesis 1-11 describes the spread of sin and evil. If we are going to appreciate God's solution we need to understand our problem. This unit helps us to do that.

Outline

- Introduction: The spread of sin
- Encountering sin and evil in God's word and God's world
- Reflection: without excuse
- Action: "Christ died for us"

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Name different aspects of sin
2. Recognise sinful attitudes in yourself and those around you
3. Guide yourself and others in repentance

8.1 INTRODUCTION: THE SPREAD OF SIN

Genesis is full of beginnings and the initial chapters demonstrate the origins and spread of sin. After Genesis 1-2, the setting of God's Story, which could have the title 'God's Good World', Genesis 3-11 outlines the problem: A World Gone Wrong. Genesis 11:27 and the Account of Terah, Abram's father, introduces The Solution: God's Rescue Plan.

Genesis 11:10-26 is the transition between these major sections in God's Story. It is also the transition between the main sections of Genesis that we saw in Unit 2. Genesis 11:10-26 and its Account of Shem (see 11:10) takes the reader from **The Beginnings of Humanity** to **The Beginnings of Israel**.

The genealogy in 11:10-26 demonstrates the growing impact of sin as people's lives get shorter (a process begun in Genesis 5 and further predicted in Genesis 6:3).

- Look at 11:10-26 and the ages each person lives for. How long does Shem live for (v 11)? How long does Terah live for (v 26)? Have a look at the figures in between.

If we are going to see the solution clearly, we need to understand the problem fully. We began to look at this in Unit 7 when we studied Genesis 11:1-9, this unit is an opportunity to reflect on this further.

8.2 ENCOUNTERING SIN AND EVIL IN GOD'S WORD AND GOD'S WORLD

8.2.1 The spread of sin in Genesis 3-11

Death is one effect of sin. Look back through Genesis 3:1 - 11:9 and remind yourself of other aspects of sin and evil. To guide you:

- Genesis 3:16-24 reports God's curse on mankind and their banishment from Eden. What has happened to the relationships between God and mankind, mankind and mankind, and mankind and the creation?

- Genesis 6:5 is a summary of the situation. What new aspects of human sin do you notice there?

- Finally, Genesis 11:1-9, as we have seen, shows mankind in his pride setting himself up against God and God standing against mankind.

8.2.2 The New Testament diagnosis

Romans 1:18-32 expounds this picture.

- Describe sin as it is presented in this passage. What lies at its root and how does God respond to this evil?

8.2.3 Our lives today

- Think about the world around you. Think about your own heart. How does this picture of sin and evil in God's word help us to understand God's world today?

- Consider sin and evil at an individual level, a family level and in the community.

8.3 REFLECTION: "WITHOUT EXCUSE"

Romans 1:20 makes it clear that "people are without excuse".

- What excuses do we and other people make for our sin?

- Do we focus on certain sins and draw attention away from our own sin and its seriousness?

8.4 ACTION: "CHRIST DIED FOR US"

Earlier, in Romans 4:7-8, Paul quotes from Psalm 32.

Use Psalm 32:1-5 to reflect on your own sin and as a way to deepen your repentance and faith in Christ Jesus:

[1] Blessed is the one
whose transgressions are forgiven,
whose sins are covered.
[2] Blessed is the one
whose sin the Lord does not count against them
and in whose spirit is no deceit.

- Remember the blessings of forgiveness.

[3] When I kept silent,
my bones wasted away
through my groaning all day long.
[4] For day and night
your hand was heavy on me;
my strength was sapped
as in the heat of summer.

- Remember how draining and fruitless it is to hide your sin from the Lord.

[5] Then I acknowledged my sin to you
and did not cover up my iniquity.
I said, 'I will confess
my transgressions to the Lord.'

- Remember how simple it is to come clean with God.

And you forgave
the guilt of my sin.

- Remember how God loves to hear and answer our confession of sin.

Unit 9. Genesis 15 (Encounter)

This unit applies the lessons of Unit 2 to Genesis 15. Refer back to previous 'Encountering the Bible' units for learning outline and outcomes.

As with previous units that encounter Bible passages, give the participants an opportunity to apply the steps for themselves and help them with the process.

Use the space below for additional notes (the passage has been divided between the following two pages):

9.1 WORKSHEET FOR THE PASSAGE

15 After this, the word of the Lord came to
Abram in a vision:

‘Do not be afraid, Abram.
I am your shield,
your very great reward.’

2 But Abram said, ‘Sovereign Lord, what
can you give me since I remain childless
and the one who will inherit my estate is
Eliezer of Damascus?’ **3** And Abram said,
‘You have given me no children; so a
servant in my household will be my heir.’
4 Then the word of the Lord came to
him: ‘This man will not be your heir, but a
son who is your own flesh and blood will
be your heir.’ **5** He took him outside and
said, ‘Look up at the sky and count the
stars – if indeed you can count them.’
Then he said to him, ‘So shall your
offspring be.’
6 Abram believed the Lord, and he
credited it to him as righteousness.
7 He also said to him, ‘I am the Lord,
who brought you out of Ur of the
Chaldeans to give you this land to take
possession of it.’
8 But Abram said, ‘Sovereign Lord, how
can I know that I shall gain possession of
it?’
9 So the Lord said to him, ‘Bring me a
heifer, a goat and a ram, each three years
old, along with a dove and a young
pigeon.’

10 Abram brought all these to him, cut them in two and arranged the halves opposite each other; the birds, however, he did not cut in half. 11 Then birds of prey came down on the carcasses, but Abram drove them away.

12 As the sun was setting, Abram fell into a deep sleep, and a thick and dreadful darkness came over him. 13 Then the Lord said to him, ‘Know for certain that for four hundred years your descendants will be strangers in a country not their own and that they will be enslaved and ill-treated there. 14 But I will punish the nation they serve as slaves, and afterwards they will come out with great possessions. 15 You, however, will go to your ancestors in peace and be buried at a good old age. 16 In the fourth generation your descendants will come back here, for the sin of the Amorites has not yet reached its full measure.’

17 When the sun had set and darkness had fallen, a smoking brazier with a blazing torch appeared and passed between the pieces. 18 On that day the Lord made a covenant with Abram and said, ‘To your descendants I give this land, from the Wadi of Egypt to the great river, the Euphrates – 19 the land of the Kenites, Kenizzites, Kadmonites, 20 Hittites, Perizzites, Rephaites, 21 Amorites, Canaanites, Girgashites and Jebusites.’ (NIV)

9.2 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING GENESIS 15 – STEP 1

STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text	
a) Set the passage in context. How does the passage relate to the book as a whole?	
b) See the details of the text. List important words, phrases, and relationships:	**c) Seek the meaning from the details** Explain important words, phrases, and relationships:
d) Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?	

9.3 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING GENESIS 15 – STEPS 2 TO 4

STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text **a) Note all the bones in the structure.** What elements highlight the structure?
b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure. What are the most important parts of the structure? Can you describe the main sections?
STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text **a) State the theme of the passage.** What is the author's main point?
b) Explain the message of the passage. What is the author saying about his theme?
STEP 4: BRAIN – first, understand the PURPOSE of the text... **a) State the purpose of the passage.** Why is the author making his point?
b) Make connections for teaching today. What is the relevance of this for us?

9.4 PREACHING GENESIS 15

In order to consider how to preach Genesis 15 we will, first, respond to the message at a more personal level, picking up on the discoveries we have already made. We will then use the table on the next page to capture some key ideas for a sermon or talk.

9.4.1 Responding to the message of Genesis 15

Here are three simple questions to use as we respond to God's word to us in the passage:

1. In what ways does the theme and the message of the passage speak to you personally?

2. How does the purpose and the relevance of the passage reinforce God's word to you?

3. Do you now have an important message that you want to share with other people? State and explain that message using your own words.

9.4.2 Preaching the message of Genesis 15

Use the table below to outline some of the key ideas in your sermon or talk:

STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon My sermon's purpose statement:
STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon My sermon's theme and its message statement:
STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon My sermon's outline (with the main points, introduction and conclusion):
STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon My sermon's details (note here key words, explanations, illustrations and applications that will help you write notes or a full sermon):

Unit 10. God's covenants and our covenants (Reflection)

Overview

The Pentateuch is foundational in scripture and its presentation of God's covenants is central to that. This unit explores those covenants.

Outline

- Introducing covenants
- Encountering God's covenants
- Responding to God's covenants

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. List the main elements in a covenant
2. Compare different biblical covenants
3. Illustrate ways in which Christ brings about a new and better covenant

10.1 INTRODUCING COVENANTS

A covenant is binding agreement or contract between two people or groups of people for a set purpose, with various commitments and responsibilities which define the relationship.

- What formal agreements and commitments are you familiar with in your context and culture? Name a few of the most important.

- How are such agreements or pacts made? Describe one and tell the story behind it.

- EXTRA (if you complete the above). Do any of these agreements have common parts to them? List the elements or components that some local commitments share.

10.2 ENCOUNTERING GOD'S COVENANTS

We have begun to think about some of the covenants or formal, binding agreements in our world. Covenants were also common in biblical times. Throughout this module we have seen the central importance of God's promises in God's story. Covenants provide a formal setting for these promises, and are equally important. We therefore need to take a close look at them, understanding God's covenants will help us to:

- Understand God and his promises better
- Follow God's story more carefully and intelligently
- Understand the Pentateuch more clearly
- Have a foundation for understanding the rest of God's story, including, later, the prophets
- Appreciate God's new covenant in Christ better

10.2.1 Covenants between unequal partners

Just as in our world, there were different types of covenants in the ancient world. Some were between unequal partners – for example between a sovereign power and a weaker, conquered state. And some, such as business agreements, were between equal partners.

All of God's covenants are between unequal partners, because God has no equal. They are between the Sovereign LORD and his people, who he vowed to bless and protect.

10.2.2 Covenants of grace

In all God's covenants:

God makes the first move
God declares the covenant; he makes the first move and takes the initiative. It might be in response to something mankind does, as in the case of Noah's blamelessness (Genesis 6:8-9), but even then it is God who takes charge as the Sovereign LORD, it is his covenant (Genesis 9:9). But often it is unexpected grace, as in the case of Abram in Genesis 12:1.

God makes promises
God commits himself to certain promises that lie right at the heart of the agreement. He remains sovereign and free but because of who he is he chooses to make the commitment, and that commitment is as reliable as the one who makes it, God himself (Hebrews 6:13-15).

God expects a response
God takes the initiative and God makes the promises – all his covenants are acts of grace. But God expects a response of loyalty and obedience, and the laws and regulations provide a clear indicator of that obedience or of disobedience.

- What do these features of covenants teach us about the character of God?

  God is a gracious and forgiving and sovereign God who puts relationship with his people at the heart of his dealings with his world.

10.2.3 Covenants with common elements

We will note a number of Old Testament covenants but in the story of God's people the Sinai covenant is central and more developed. It is established in Exodus and developed in in Leviticus and Numbers. But it is captured in a single document when it is renewed and repeated in Deuteronomy (which means 'second-law'). There it takes the form of a

treaty between a stronger, sovereign state and a weaker partner. Technically this is known as a 'Suzerain-Vassal Treaty.' It has five components:

1. **Preamble and historical prologue** (Deut. 1-4)

2. **Regulations** (Deut. 5-26)

3. **Documentation** (Deut. 27 and 31)

4. **Incentives** (Deut. 28-29 and 32-33)

5. **Witnesses** (Deut. 30:19-20; 31:26)

In keeping with such agreements there are two copies, one for each party. And in the case of the two stone tablets, with the Ten Commandments inscribed by God on them, it is likely that rather than commandments 1-5 being on one tablet and 6-10 on the other tablet, all ten were written on both tablets, and both copies were then placed in the Ark of the Covenant.

While the Sinai Covenant has all these elements in it as a later and fully developed 'Suzerain-Vassal Treaty' all God's covenants have the core elements. We could give them these four more general headings:

1. Setting
The situation that led to the agreement and the history surrounding it.

2. Commitment
The promises that are made and that form the heart of the agreement. We can use our four 'golden threads' to consider the commitment that is made (God's place, God's people, God's presence, and God's purpose).

3. Response
The practical obedience that must result from the covenant commitment and relationship.

4. Motivation
The incentives to encourage covenant loyalty and obedience (in the form of blessings for obedience and curses for disobedience).

We can trace these elements through the five main covenants: with Noah; with Abraham; at Sinai; with David; and the New Covenant. The table on the next page lists those five covenants along the top and their component parts down the side.

If you are part of a large group, share the covenants between small groups or individuals and consider some of the passages.

	Background What led to the agreement?	**Commitment** What promises were made?*	**Response** What form of obedience is called for?	**Motivation** What incentives are there?
God's Covenant with Noah Gen 6:18-21; 8:20-9:17				
God's Covenant with Abraham Gen 12:1-3; 15:1-21; 17:1-27				
God's Covenant at Sinai Exod 6:6-8; 19:3-6; 24.				
God's Covenant with David 2 Sam 7; 23:1-7. Ps 89				
God's New Covenant Jer 31:31-34. Ezek 34, 36 & 37. Isa 40-55.				

*Can you see any of the four 'golden-threads'? (God's promise of a place, a people, his presence, a purpose)

10.3 RESPONDING TO GOD'S COVENANTS

- Read through Deut 10:12-22. In what ways were God's people to respond to his covenant with him?

- How can this guide us in our response?

- Hebrews makes it clear that "Christ is the mediator of a new covenant" (9:15). Do we need to respond to this new covenant in a new way?

- Do you think the way in which God makes covenants can inform the way we make commitments to other people? If so, how?

Unit 11. Exodus 3:1-12 (Encounter)

This unit applies the lessons of Unit 2 to Exodus 3. Refer back to previous 'Encountering the Bible' units for learning outline and outcomes. It includes an introduction to Exodus.

As with previous units that encounter Bible passages, give the participants an opportunity to apply the steps for themselves and help them with the process. The unit includes an introduction to Exodus.

11.1 INTRODUCING THE BOOK OF EXODUS

Exodus is the second of the five books of Moses, the Pentateuch. It picks up the story from Genesis, with God's people in Egypt. In 2.5.1 we said this of the conclusion of Genesis:

> "Take a look at Genesis 50:22-26 and see how it masterfully draws together the threads of the book and points forward to Exodus (you can then turn over to Exodus 1:1-7 and see how Exodus picks up the story)."

- Turn to those two passages again to reinforce the connection between these two volumes in the Pentateuch.

In 1.3.1. we summarised what we learnt of God in Genesis as, 'The God who makes and keeps promises'. And we noted that God in Exodus is shown to be, 'The God who delivers and is with his people'. Read on in Exodus 1 from v. 8 to v. 14. And turn to the important summary of their situation at the end of Chapter 2 (vv. 23-25).

> "23 During that long period, the king of Egypt died. The Israelites groaned in their slavery and cried out, and their cry for help because of their slavery went up to God. 24 God heard their groaning and he remembered his covenant with Abraham, with Isaac and with Jacob. 25 So God looked on the Israelites and was concerned about them."

- Can you summarise the situation of God's people in Egypt, their need, and what we learn about their God?

11.2 FOUR STEPS IN UNDERSTANDING THE BOOK OF EXODUS

2. God's salvation PICTURED

Exodus paints a picture or model of salvation as a people, Israel, is rescued, the promise is renewed, the Law given and God comes to dwell with them, pictured by his glory filling the tabernacle (Exodus 40:35). Leviticus builds on that with the explanation of the sacrifices and the exposition of the Law. Numbers tests the relationship and Deuteronomy recaps it all on the edge of the land (Deuteronomy means 'second law'). This module not only looks at the promise of salvation, but also begins to develop this picture.

The Psalms (Module Six) and the Wisdom writing (Module Eight) are set in and reflect on the story of the land in different ways. If you are going to look at one passage, Exodus 19:5-6 is a reminder of God's presence with and through his people.

2.7 COMBINING THE THREADS AND STAGES OF SALVATION
1B. God's people pictured
In Exod 19 and 20 God's recently rescued people are gathered before God to receive his covenant as "a holy nation" (19:1-6). This picture of God's people is developed through the OT story.
2B. God's place pictured
12 leaders explore the land in Num 13. But due to rebellion the land will not be entered for 40 years (14:34). Joshua describes the conquest, a mixed picture that leads into the rest of the OT story.
3B. God's presence pictured
Exodus pictures God's presence: from the burning bush of 3:2, and the pillar of cloud and fire leading the people (13:21), to God's glory filling his tabernacle (40:34), it is a mark of God's people (33:15).
4B. God's purpose pictured
Exodus reveals God's people as a holy people for the nations (19:5-6). Their distinctive life of justice reaches a peak in 1 Kgs 10: the wisdom of Solomon draws the world to Israel and their God.

11.3 WORKSHEET FOR THE PASSAGE

1 Now Moses was tending the flock of Jethro his father-in-law, the priest of Midian, and he led the flock to the far side of the wilderness and came to Horeb, the mountain of God. **2** There the angel of the Lord appeared to him in flames of fire from within a bush. Moses saw that though the bush was on fire it did not burn up. **3** So Moses thought, 'I will go over and see this strange sight – why the bush does not burn up.'

4 When the Lord saw that he had gone over to look, God called to him from within the bush, 'Moses! Moses!'

And Moses said, 'Here I am.'

5 'Do not come any closer,' God said. 'Take off your sandals, for the place where you are standing is holy ground.' **6** Then he said, 'I am the God of your father, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac and the God of Jacob.' At this, Moses hid his face, because he was afraid to look at God.

7 The Lord said, ‘I have indeed seen the
misery of my people in Egypt. I have heard
them crying out because of their slave
drivers, and I am concerned about their
suffering. 8 So I have come down to rescue
them from the hand of the Egyptians and
to bring them up out of that land into a
good and spacious land, a land flowing
with milk and honey – the home of the
Canaanites, Hittites, Amorites, Perizzites,
Hivites and Jebusites. 9 And now the cry of
the Israelites has reached me, and I have
seen the way the Egyptians are
oppressing them. 10 So now, go. I am
sending you to Pharaoh to bring my people
the Israelites out of Egypt.’

11 But Moses said to God, ‘Who am I that
I should go to Pharaoh and bring the
Israelites out of Egypt?’

12 And God said, ‘I will be with you. And
this will be the sign to you that it is I who
have sent you: when you have brought the
people out of Egypt, you will worship God
on this mountain.’

13 Moses said to God, ‘Suppose I go to
the Israelites and say to them, “The God of
your fathers has sent me to you,” and they
ask me, “What is his name?” Then what
shall I tell them?’

14 God said to Moses, ‘I AM WHO I AM.
This is what you are to say to the Israelites:
“I AM has sent me to you.”’ (NIV)

11.4 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING EXODUS 3:1-12 – STEP 1

STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text	
a) Set the passage in context. How does the passage relate to the book as a whole?	
b) See the details of the text. List important words, phrases, and relationships:	**c) Seek the meaning from the details** Explain important words, phrases, and relationships:
d) Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?	

11.5 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING EXODUS 3:1-12 – STEPS 2 TO 4

STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text **a) Note all the bones in the structure.** What elements highlight the structure?
b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure. What are the most important parts of the structure? Can you describe the main sections?
STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text **a) State the theme of the passage.** What is the author's main point?
b) Explain the message of the passage. What is the author saying about his theme?
STEP 4: BRAIN – first, understand the PURPOSE of the text... **a) State the purpose of the passage.** Why is the author making his point?
b) Make connections for teaching today. What is the relevance of this for us?

11.6 PREACHING EXODUS 3:1-12

In order to consider how to preach Exodus 3:1-12 we will, first, respond to the message at a more personal level, picking up on the discoveries we have already made. We will then use the table on the next page to capture some key ideas for a sermon or talk.

11.6.1 Responding to the message of Exodus 3:1-12

Here are three simple exercises to do in response to God's word to us in the passage we have just encountered:

1. Describe how the message you discovered in the passage spoke to you personally: What did you learn or need to be reminded of?

2. Share how the purpose of the passage helped you to apply God's word to your life: What change will this passage make to your thinking and living?

3. State and explain the message you will share with others using your own words: What is the main thing you want people to understand?

11.6.2 Preaching the message of Exodus 3:1-12

Use the table below to outline some of the key ideas in your sermon or talk:

STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon My sermon's purpose statement:
STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon My sermon's theme and its message statement:
STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon My sermon's outline (with the main points, introduction and conclusion):
STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon My sermon's details (note here key words, explanations, illustrations and applications that will help you write notes or a full sermon):

Unit 12. Jesus and the Old Testament (Reflection)

Overview

Exodus 3 reveals God as the ever present God who rescues his people. That thread runs through the Bible, finding its fulfilment in Christ. This unit explores those themes: the presence of God and how Jesus relates to the Old Testament and the Old Testament to Jesus.

Outline

- Introduction: Progressive revelation
- The ever present God
- Jesus as the ever present God
- Jesus and the Old Testament
- The four golden threads in the Bible's story and Christ
- Seven ways in which the Old Testament points to Jesus
- The sacrifices of Leviticus and the sacrifice of Christ
- Jesus and the Old Testament Law

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Explain the meaning of 'progressive revelation'
2. Show the significance of the name 'Yahweh', the LORD, from Exodus 3:13-17
3. Summarise the way in which the Old Testament relates to the New Testament
4. List and discuss ways in which the Old Testament points to Jesus

12.1 INTRODUCTION: PROGRESSIVE REVELATION

Progressive revelation is a technical term for the way in which God reveals more and more of who he is through the course of the Bible.

- Look back through Genesis and discuss the way in which the picture of who God is develops through the story. (Use the outline of Genesis on the next page and think through some of what we come to know about God at each stage.)

Introduction
1:1 – 2:3 "In the beginning" – setting the scene

1. The beginning of humanity
2:4 – 4: 26 The account of the heavens and the earth
5:1 – 6:8 The account of Adam
6:9 – 9:26 The account of Noah
9:27 – 11:9 The account of the sons of Noah
11:10 – 11:26 The account of Shem

2. The beginning of Israel
11:27 – 25:11 The account of Terah (and his son Abraham)
25:12 – 18 The account of Ishmael
25:19 – 35:29 The account of Isaac
36:1 – 37:1 The account of Esau
37:2 – 50:26 The account of Jacob

12.2 THE EVER PRESENT GOD

12.2.1 The ever present God revealed to Moses

Exodus picks up from where Genesis left off and continues this progressive revelation. Exodus 3:1-12 and the explanation of the name of God that follows is an important moment in this. It provides the foundation for the relationship between the LORD and his people.

Take a look at **Exodus 3:13-17**:

> 13 Moses said to God, 'Suppose I go to the Israelites and say to them, "The God of your fathers has sent me to you," and they ask me, "What is his name?" Then what shall I tell them?'
>
> 14 God said to Moses, 'I am who I am. This is what you are to say to the Israelites: "I am has sent me to you."'
>
> 15 God also said to Moses, 'Say to the Israelites, "The LORD, the God of your fathers – the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac and the God of Jacob – has sent me to you."
>
> 'This is my name for ever,
> the name you shall call me
> from generation to generation.
>
> 16 'Go, assemble the elders of Israel and say to them, "The LORD, the God of your fathers – the God of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob – appeared to me and said: I have watched over you and have seen what has been done to you in Egypt. 17 And I have promised to bring you up out of your misery in Egypt into the land of the Canaanites, Hittites, Amorites, Perizzites, Hivites and Jebusites – a land flowing with milk and honey."

- Can you see the way in which this passage picks up the four golden threads that run through the Bible?

- In what ways does this passage build on what we have learnt about God already?

In v 15 God gives his name as 'Yahweh', which sounds very similar to the Hebrew "I am" and is translated 'The LORD' in the passage:

> "The LORD, the God of your fathers – the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac and the God of Jacob – has sent me to you."

In the context of the promise to overthrow a major world power, God reveals himself to be of supreme authority: the ever-present, ever-living, everlasting God who is always with them – the God whose Presence goes with them.

The third golden thread, God's Presence, takes centre stage in Exodus and when the book speaks of his Presence it uses his ever-present name, 'The LORD' (Yahweh). If you have time look at Exodus 19-20, where the LORD is present on the mountain at the giving of the Law. And Exodus 33-34 where it is clear that God's Presence with his people is their unique and distinguishing feature (33:15-16).

12.2.2 The ever present God as the hope of Israel

This truth about the ever present God who makes promises to his people and who rescues them from bondage runs through the Pentateuch and flows out into the Old Testament as a whole. It is picked up repeatedly and becomes the bedrock for the hope of the prophets, as we will see in later modules. For example, Isaiah 41:4, in speaking of the LORD as a sovereign redeemer declares:

> Who has done this and carried it through,
> calling forth the generations from the beginning?
> I, the Lord – with the first of them
> and with the last – I am he.'

Do you see how that looks back to the God of the Exodus and his revelation of himself at the burning bush?

And all the golden threads are also heading forwards: towards Jesus. For the Christian this important passage gives fresh momentum to the revelation of God and his saving purposes, which find their fulfilment in Jesus, which means 'Saviour'.

12.3 JESUS AS THE EVER PRESENT GOD

This progressive revelation of who God is finds its fulfilment in Christ. John's gospel has seven 'I am' sayings, beginning with "I am the bread of life" in John 6:35 (the others are in 8:12, 10:7, 10:11, 11:25, 14:6 and 15:1). Those may well echo the 'I am' of Exodus 3:14 and surrounding verses. But whether they do or not, John 8:58 clearly does:

> 'Very truly I tell you,' Jesus answered, 'before Abraham was born, I am!'

That saying makes little sense and impact without the Exodus background, with it we can see that Jesus is the eternal God, who comes into his world doing and saying the things that God alone can do and say. And he comes as the hope and comfort of God's people who heard the words of Isaiah.

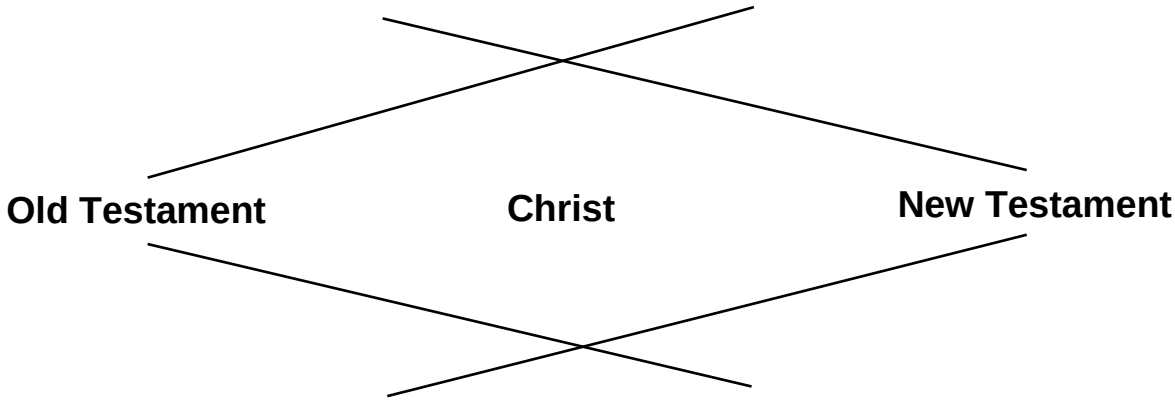
12.4 JESUS AND THE OLD TESTAMENT

12.4.1 The Old sheds light on the New and the New sheds light on the Old

In other words we come to understand the significance of Jesus as we come to understand all that the prophets and all the scriptures were saying (to use Jesus' own words, which we will see in a moment).

And we also come to understand the full significance of the Old Testament writings in the light of what the New Testament tells us about Christ.

The Old sheds light on the New and the New sheds light on the Old. And as we read one in the light of the other we see Jesus more and more clearly.



Jesus explains this process in Luke 24:13-35. You may remember the story. Two of the wider group of disciples are on their way to Emmaus and Jesus joins them and listens in on all they are saying about the events surrounding Jesus' death in Jerusalem. They "had hoped that he was the one who was going to redeem Israel". They had hoped that he would complete God's plan of salvation.

What is it that leads them to fully recognise who Jesus really is? Take a look at the central verses in that passage, vv 25-27:

> "He said to them, 'How foolish you are, and how slow to believe all that the prophets have spoken! Did not the Messiah have to suffer these things and then enter his glory?' And beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he explained to them what was said in all the Scriptures concerning himself."

Jesus makes it clear that in order to recognise Jesus as Saviour, they and we need to do two things: 1. We need "to believe all that the prophets have spoken", and 2. We need to understand "what was said in all the Scriptures concerning himself", that is Jesus. Those are two different things.

12.4.2 We need "to believe all that the prophets have spoken"

In other words it is no good only believing some of what the prophets said. We need to understand their full message: "Did not the Messiah have to suffer these things and then enter his glory?' Suffering and glory, not one or the other but both.

For example, take a look at Isaiah 42:1-4 and see how that brings those together. It is the New Testament that sheds light on that, it is Jesus who explains that, and it is Jesus we come to understand as we consider his life, death and resurrection in the light of the scriptures.

12.4.3 We need to understand "what was said in all the Scriptures"

We need to understand "what was said in all the Scriptures" concerning Jesus. We need to discover that full message by drawing on the whole Old Testament.

The phrase, "Moses and all the Prophets" (Luke 24:27) is shorthand for what is written more fully in Luke 24:44: "the Law of Moses, the Prophets and the Psalms." Jesus was referring to the three divisions of the Hebrew Scriptures: The Law, The Prophets and The Writings, which we learnt about in Unit 1. All of the Old Testament is important.

- In what ways does the Old Testament point to Jesus, and in what ways does the New Testament draw on the Old Testament in order to explain the full significance of Jesus?

12.5 THE FOUR GOLDEN THREADS IN THE BIBLE'S STORY AND CHRIST

In Unit 2 we saw the 'four golden threads' or elements of God's promise to Abram, which run through the Bible and its parts and stages.

God's salvation is finally proclaimed in Jesus Christ. All four of the threads therefore come together in him.

- Can you think of ways in which this is true? Fill in the table below.

		How is each thread in God's salvation proclaimed in Christ?
God's promise of ...	**People**	*Jesus Christ represents God's people as a faithful remnant. He begins a new people, a New Israel, the Church, founded on the 12 Apostles.*
	Place	*Jesus Christ is God's temple. In Christ and his people we find all that the land gave: belonging, citizenship, identity, provision.*
	Presence	*Jesus Christ brings God's presence to us, and leaves God's presence, the Holy Spirit, with us.*
	Purpose	*Jesus Christ fulfils God's mission or purpose. But we then find our purpose in him as we share the good news of his Kingdom with others.*

And all these elements, which are focussed on Christ, are then completed in the New Creation.

12.6 SEVEN WAYS IN WHICH THE OLD TESTAMENT POINTS TO JESUS

Taking it further, here are seven ways in which the Old Testament points to Jesus. You might not have time to cover all these points in your group study, but this will give you a framework to consider and to teach about how Jesus relates to the Old Testament. Your trainer will help you to fill out the points and identify some New Testament texts to illustrate them. This draws on Chris Wright, *Knowing Jesus through the Old Testament*.

12.6.1 Jesus fits the Old Testament identity

The Old Testament paints a complex portrait of the coming Messiah, a detailed picture of his identity. The Jesus of the New Testament matches all the parts of that identity.

Luke 3:22 presents a glorious thumbnail of that identity. There the voice of the Father echoes at least three Old Testament texts: "And a voice came from heaven: 'You are my Son, whom I love; with you I am well pleased.'"

- Turn to Psalm 2.7, Genesis 22.2 and Isaiah 42.1, note their contents and meaning, and see how they are brought together in Luke 3:22.

12.6.2 Jesus completes the Old Testament story

As we have been discovering, the Old Testament tells an unfinished story, which Jesus completes and the New Testament explains. Luke 3 immediately moves from that declaration of God the Father in v. 22 to dig back into the Old Testament story in v. 23: "He was the son, so it was thought, of Joseph…" To take this further, Matthew's own genealogy in Matt 1 tells the same story in a different way, in three movements: From Abraham to David (vv. 1-6); from David to the exile to Babylon (vv. 6-11); from the Exile to the Messiah (vv. 7-17, a movement summarised in v. 17.

- Look at Matthew 1 and trace and note the movement of God's story from Abraham to Jesus.

12.6.3 Jesus fulfils the Old Testament promises

The Old Testament is full of God's promises, from the foundational ones we have explored in Gen 12:1-3.

- Turn to 2 Cor 1:20 to see what Paul tells us about the relationship between these promises and Jesus, Messiah, and to discuss what that means.

"For no matter how many promises God has made, they are "Yes" in Christ."

12.6.4 Jesus accomplishes the Old Testament mission

The Old Testament launches God's mission to the world, which we have begun to explore, beginning with the promises in Gen 12:1-3, with their promise of a purpose for God's people. As the story moves forward it becomes increasingly focussed not only on one people, Israel, but one person, a servant who will represent God's people. Isaiah speaks most clearly of this servant (for example in Isaiah 42:1-4 as we have already noted, a theme we will explore more in Module 3 and Module 9.

- Turn to Mark 10:45 to see how the evangelist draws on this theme and applies it to Jesus.

"… the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many." (Mark 10:45)

12.6.5 Jesus gives substance to the Old Testament shadows

In Colossians 2:17 Paul refers to religious ceremonies in order to put them in their proper place. He tells us that they are, "a shadow of the things that were to come; the reality, however, is found in Christ." This includes the way in which Jesus keeps the Old Testament law, as we will see in a moment. But it has a broader meaning to it: Jesus is the one who makes all the hopes, expectations and longings that the Old Testament creates a reality.

- Think through the ways in which that is true and the encouragement that brings.

12.6.6 Jesus perfects the Old Testament prototypes

A prototype is an initial version of something that an engineer builds or a designer creates to test and develop a machine or other product. The Old Testament is full of such prototypes in God's plan of salvation.

- Look up Hebrews 9:9 and begin to consider how Jesus perfects the sacrificial system, which we will turn to in a moment.

"This is an illustration for the present time, indicating that the gifts and sacrifices being offered were not able to clear the conscience of the worshiper." Hebrews 9:9

12.6.7 Jesus keeps the Old Testament law

In the next unit we will encounter God's Law and its various aspects. That will include exploring how the Law and its individual laws point forward to Christ and the gospel. But it will also include Jesus' own attitude and relationship to the Law as he refers back to it and keeps the Old Testament Law in the fullest sense.

- For now, turn to Matthew 5:17 and note what Jesus says of his relationship to the Law, which we will then look at further in the next unit.

"Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfil them" (Matt 5:17). All we need to note for now is that Jesus does not simply replace the law and render it irrelevant, instead it has an enduring relevance in him. The NIV translates Romans 10:4 this way, "Christ is the culmination of the law so that there may be righteousness for everyone who believes." 'Culmination' means the climax or coming together of things.

12.7 THE OFFERINGS IN LEVITICUS AND THE SACRIFICE OF CHRIST

> "Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets;
> I have not come to abolish them but to fulfil them." (Matthew 5:17)

We have seen that "Jesus keeps the Old Testament Law" in the fullest sense: he is its climax and everything it points to, and he keeps and completes all its demands. The sacrificial system is part of that, as we will see in the next unit. If you have time at this point, introduce yourselves to that system in Leviticus by noting the basic sacrifices there.

Building on that last point, Leviticus 1-5 describes the five offerings that are perfected in the sacrifice of Christ. As the titles in the NIV indicate the first five chapters of the book introduce the five offerings, before chapters 6 and 7 add to the descriptions of each.

1. The burnt offering (Lev 1)
The destruction of the offering in the place of sinner. Pointing to the way in which Christ is destroyed in our place: at great cost God finds a way of destroying sin without destroying us.

2. The grain offering (Lev 2)
Offering a portion of produce back to God. Christ himself represents his people as he is offered to God.

3. The fellowship offering (Lev 3)
Communion with God as the worshipper participates and eats some of it. Pointing to the blessing of fellowship with God in Christ.

4. The sin offering (Lev 4)
Identification with the sacrifice that absorbs the sin. Pointing to the way in which Christ absorbs our sin and shame on our behalf at the cost of his precious blood.

5. The guilt offering (Lev 5)
Closely linked with the above, this offering removes not only the filth of sin but the guilt of sin. Forgiveness is added to cleansing, pointing to the way in which Christ deals with not only the filth of our sin but its guilt too.

All these aspect find fulfilment in Christ, as does the law more generally. We will now look at this more closely in our next unit, ‘Encountering the Law’.

Unit 13. Encountering the Law (Tools)

Overview

The Pentateuch tells God's story through stories. Other types of literature are embedded in those stories. The Law is central to the story, as well as being a type of writing that must be read and applied with great care. This Unit looks at how we can do that and prepares us for Unit 14.

Outline

- Encountering the Law
- The 'BUILD' framework for encountering the Law
- Jesus and the Law in the Sermon on the Mount
- Encountering specific laws

Outcomes

At the end of the unit you will be able to

1. List the different places in the Pentateuch where the Law is found
2. Describe the main types of laws
3. Use the 'BUILD' framework of the Bible's story to discuss different laws and their meaning today

This unit takes a number of the concepts and approaches in the module and uses them to help participants to appreciate, understand and apply the Law and the laws of the Old Testament or Covenant.

13.1 ENCOUNTERING THE LAW

13.1.1 Encountering specific laws

- Look up these verses in your Bible and comment on the laws they contain and how you think they might apply today: Exodus 23:4; Exodus 23:17; Exodus 23:19; Leviticus 19:19; Leviticus 19:27.

- Discuss some of these questions: How might we understand and apply these and other laws today? Do such laws undermine the gospel of God's grace?

- Finally, you might like to share ways in which leaders and churches misinterpret the Old Testament laws, and some of the problems that result.

13.1.2 Encountering the difficulties surrounding the Law

The Law and its laws raise many questions. In addition to those above there are also these: Where do we find the various laws? Given that the laws seem to be mixed together in the Pentateuch, how do we begin to separate them out?

And even the term 'The Law' is used in different ways in the Pentateuch. It can mean:

- God's general standards;
- God's word;
- The Pentateuch as a whole;
- Deuteronomy as a book;
- The Ten Commandments;
- The Book of the Law within Exodus.

It is no wonder that people can feel rather confused!

13.1.3 Ceremonial, civil and moral: can we separate out the laws?

What about the distinction people make between ceremonial, civil and moral law? Can we separate them out in that way?

The Church of Uganda is an Anglican Church which takes the 'Thirty Nine Articles of the Church of England' as one of its foundational documents. Article Seven, 'Of the Old Testament', makes this distinction:

> Where "the Law given from God by Moses" touches on ceremonial and civil matters it is no longer binding, but no Christian person "is free from the obedience of the Commandments which are called Moral".

Do you see what that is saying? The argument is that the ceremonial laws are fulfilled in Christ and the civil law applied to the nation of Israel and is no longer directly applicable. That leaves only 'the moral law' to apply to believers. There are some helpful principles in that argument, but it is impossible to completely separate out these elements of the law. At best we can say that there are ceremonial, civil and moral aspects to it, but there are others too.

Therefore we need to keep those distinctions in mind but we also need to find other ways of thinking about how to understand and apply this important part of God's word, not least ways that make sense of the enduring relevance of the whole of the Law. As Jesus said: "Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfil them" (Matthew 5:17).

13.2 THE 'BUILD' FRAMEWORK FOR ENCOUNTERING THE LAW

To help us encounter the Law on its own terms we will ask these four questions in relation to the Law: Why? Where? What? and How?

13.2.1 Why was the Law given?

Throughout the BUILD curriculum we emphasise that the context is the key. And that certainly applies to interpreting the Law. In Unit 14 we will encounter Deuteronomy 5:6-21, which contains the Ten Commandments as they are preached again by Moses on

the edge of the Promised Land. Verse 6 stands right at the beginning of those 'ten words' and gives a vital context for them:

"I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of Egypt, out of the land of slavery."

What does that context tell us about the content of the Law that follows? It reminds us of this important truth: the Law is for God's redeemed people, it is not given in order to redeem God's people. It is intended to guide those who have been saved rather than to save them. It is a gift of God's grace.

From the perspective of Exodus, which we studied in Unit 11, the Law is given after nineteen chapters that describe God's great salvation.

Deuteronomy 6:20-25 reminds us of this important setting. There it foresees children asking their parents the same question we are considering in this unit, "What is the meaning of the stipulations, decrees and laws the Lord our God has commanded you?"

The answer is not, first, to tease them apart and explain the details but to tell the story of God's salvation, how he kept his promises and the need for obedience so that they might be blessed and remain in right relationship with the LORD of the covenant.

Deuteronomy 5:1-5 underlines all this:

> **1** Moses summoned all Israel and said:
> Hear, O Israel, the decrees and laws I declare in your hearing today. Learn them and be sure to follow them. **2** The LORD our God made a covenant with us at Horeb. **3** It was not with our fathers that the LORD made this covenant, but with us, with all of us who are alive here today. **4** The LORD spoke to you face to face out of the fire on the mountain. **5** (At that time I stood between the LORD and you to declare to you the word of the LORD, because you were afraid of the fire and did not go up the mountain.)

- What additional insights do you see in that passage?

Note there that the Law begins with the LORD it is his Law and is all about relationship with him. That relationship is a covenant one – the Law is repeatedly referred to as 'the law of the covenant' in the Pentateuch. The Law of God is all about how loyalty to the covenant is shown. It is ongoing: "It was not with our fathers that the LORD made this covenant, but with us, with all of us" – or more simply 'not only, but also' it is a covenant that is continually renewed with God's people.

13.2.2 Where do we find the Law and the laws?

The Where? and What? of the Law, below, draws on Christopher Wright's book, 'Living as the People of God'. It is easy to feel overwhelmed by the size of the Pentateuch and helpful to see where we actually find the laws within in. There are four main places:

1. "The Ten Commandments" – Exodus 20:2-7 and Deuteronomy 5:6-21
"The Ten Commandments" is how this foundational set of commands is referred to in Exodus 34:28, literally 'the ten words' (if you have heard the word Decalogue that is where that originates from). The Ten Commandments are found in Exodus 20:2-17 and are taught to a new generation in Deuteronomy 5:6-21. In Deuteronomy 5:22 Moses makes it clear that they are complete: The LORD "added nothing more". The Ten

Commandments are foundational and everything else is, in a sense, explanation and application.

2. "The Book of the Covenant" – Exodus 20:22 – 23:33
"The Book of the Covenant", which is what it is called in Exodus 24:7 is found in Exodus 20:22 – 23:33 (after a short introduction the Lord says: "These are the laws you are to set before them:"). It is therefore the first exposition of what the Ten Commandments mean in practice with very specific examples and cases of what the Law looks like in the life of Israel.

3. The Law in Leviticus
Leviticus, which means 'of the Levites' or priests, is almost entirely law and laws. Only chapters 8-10 and a short section in chapter 24 (vv 10-23) are narratives that relate closely to the law. While Leviticus is 'of the priests' in that it describes matters of worship and the appointment of the priests and the beginnings of the tabernacle system, its worship and focus on holiness applies to the whole of God's people and their life together. There is an emphasis on ceremonial and ritual issues, but also on very practical matters of holiness. A description of the rituals surrounding the forgiveness and cleansing of the Day of Atonement lies right at the centre of the book in Chapter 16. Chapters 17-26 contain The Holiness code, which demonstrates the holistic and practical nature of holiness. Chapter 19 is a self-contained example of that.

4. The "Book of the Law" – Deuteronomy
Deuteronomy refers to itself as "this Book of the Law" repeatedly (28:61; 29:21; 30:10; 31:26). And Joshua then refers to it in this way (Joshua 8:30-35). Deuteronomy literally means 'second law', meaning a second giving or proclamation of the Law. Moses preaches the law to a new generation. We will see the structure of the book in Unit 14, but in terms of where the law is found it is important to see that the Ten Commandments are given at the centre of a lengthy call to obedience (chapters 4-11). What then immediately follows at the heart of the book (chapters 12-26) is an unpacking and explanation of the law, with similarities and differences to the Book of the Covenant in Exodus. While the divisions are not neat there are laws to do with worship (12:1–16:17), laws to do with leadership (16:18–18:22), and laws to do with life in the community (19:1–25:19).

13.2.3 What sorts of Law and laws do we find?

We have seen *where* to find The Law and the laws. Next we need to look more at *what* sorts of laws there are. That will further help us to understand and apply the laws today.

1. Crime and punishment
Some of the Law and laws relate to crimes against God and his people as a nation, which is why they are punished so severely, by death. See Exodus 21:12-17; Exodus 22:20; Deuteronomy 22:22.

2. Community
Sometimes called 'civil law', which teaches how the principles of the covenant are to work out in the life of the community. See Exodus 21:18-25; Exodus 22:5-15.

3. Worship
These laws have to do with sacrifice and ceremonies, but hygiene rules are linked to these, as are laws about care for the poor (which illustrates the way the law is woven together). See Exodus 23:10-19; Deuteronomy 14:22-29.

4. Family
The family had an important role in Israel and that included a legal role in a range of issues such as land, property, marriage, slavery and the discipline of children. See Leviticus 25:23-28, 35-55; Deuteronomy 21:15-17; Deuteronomy 25:5-10.

5. Charity
Because of the way in which the Lord cared for his people they were called to care for others. See Exodus 22:21-27; Leviticus 19:9-10, 14-18, 32-34; Deuteronomy 22:1-4, 6-8; 23:15-16; 24:5-6, 10-22.

13.2.4 How do we interpret these laws today?

We have seen why the law was given and where to find the laws and what sorts of laws there are. We are already beginning to see how we might understand and apply them.

Putting the laws in the BUILD framework of understanding the story of the Bible sheds light on this area. The four golden threads in God's promise and the story of salvation, with its four stages will help us. Remember **the four golden threads** (God's promise of a people, a place, his presence and a purpose). Remember **the four stages of salvation** (God's salvation is promised, pictured, prophesied and proclaimed). Exploring these fully would be the subject of a whole module of training. But here are some questions to ask:

Threads	**How does this law relate to the different threads in God's plan?**
People	Does this law relate to the quality of relationship among God's people – demonstrating God's care for them in their care for one another? *How might that then apply to God's people today?*
Place	Does this law relate to care for and stewardship of the land God has given his people? *How might that apply today as God's people live out the values of his Kingdom and look forward to a New Creation?*
Presence	Does this law relate to God's holy presence with his people? *How might that translate into God's church today?*
Purpose	Does this law relate to Israel's call to be different to those around them, and so be a light to the nations (Exodus 19:4-6)? *What principle applies to God's people today?*

Stages	**How does this law relate to the different stages in God's plan?**
Promised	Does this law look back to all that God has promised as a reminder of his covenant relationship with his people? *How might it apply today in terms of God's New Covenant commitment to his people?*
Pictured	As with the thread of a purpose for God's people, above, does this law relate to God's people living out God's salvation as a picture for all to see? *What principles might apply today? Matthew 5:13-16*
Prophesied	Does this law call for repentance and point forward to the hope of the Kingdom of God? *In what ways does it lead us to repentance and hope?*
Proclaimed	*In what way does this law point forward to Christ and the gospel? See Unit 12.*

13.3 JESUS AND THE LAW IN THE SERMON ON THE MOUNT

We saw the importance of remembering the purpose of God's people. As the Pentateuch unfolds the promise of a **purpose** for God's people becomes a call for Israel to be a light to the nations – they are to become a **picture** of God's salvation.

The Law plays a central role in this, as Exodus 19:4-6 makes clear:

> 3 Then Moses went up to God, and the Lord called to him from the mountain and said, 'This is what you are to say to the descendants of Jacob and what you are to tell the people of Israel: 4 "You yourselves have seen what I did to Egypt, and how I carried you on eagles' wings and brought you to myself. 5 Now if you obey me fully and keep my covenant, then out of all nations you will be my treasured possession. Although the whole earth is mine, 6 you will be for me a kingdom of priests and a holy nation."

Through the Exodus God's people become Israel, a nation under God. And keeping the covenant through obedience to the Law, is how they show what this means.

Jesus is a new and better Moses (Hebrews 3:1-6) renewing the covenant on another mountain in Matthew 5, and his picture of his disciples, God's new Israel, as salt and light (Matthew 5:13-16) comes before some examples of what that means in terms of the continuing relevance of the Law (5:17-20), which leads to some specific examples of what that means in practice (5:21-48) and with some correction of misreading of the Law. Chapter 6:1-18 continues with themes from the law: charity and worship, before looking at single-mindedness and devotion, another theme from Deuteronomy. And we could continue, the parallels with Deuteronomy are numerous. The point is this:

Use the Sermon on the Mount as a lens through which to interpret the law.

In particular note the way Jesus shows the full depth of commands and the heart of the law. For example, murder includes anger as well as actually killing, which is where anger ultimately leads. We can take this further as we look at the Ten Commandments in more detail in the next unit. But before we do, we will take a look at the individual laws we began with and apply what we have learnt in this unit.

13.4 ENCOUNTERING SPECIFIC LAWS

We began with some specific laws. We will end by looking at those same laws: Exodus 23:4; Exodus 23:17; Exodus 23:19; Leviticus 19:19; Leviticus 19:27.

13.4.1 Exodus 23:4

"If you come across your enemy's ox or donkey wandering off, be sure to return it."

Why?	Remember God's salvation. His care leads to our care. Love for enemies is a model of God's love.
Where?	The Book of the Covenant. Part of the exposition of the Ten Commandments. This is the opposite of theft and coveting.
What?	Community law with a charitable aspect to it.
How?	Demonstrating the purpose of God's people as a picture of a "new commandment" to love one another. Today this means going the extra mile for others and loving those we would not naturally love, as Christ loved us.

13.4.2 Exodus 23:17

"Three times a year all the men are to appear before the Sovereign Lord."

Why?	God has rescued a people for himself, to be in relationship with him.
Where?	The Book of the Covenant. Part of the exposition of the Ten Commandments. This is part of putting God first.
What?	Part of the worship of Israel.
How?	As part of the three festivals where God's people come into God's presence. A reminder of the privilege of being with the ever present God, and the discipline of worship. And in Christ, "There is neither Jew nor Gentile, neither slave nor free, nor is there male and female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus."

13.4.3 Exodus 23:19

"Bring the best of the firstfruits of your soil to the house of the Lord your God.
"Do not cook a young goat in its mother's milk."

Why?	God has rescued them from the land of Egypt into their own land, by grace and gift.
Where?	The Book of the Covenant. Part of the exposition of the Ten Commandments, a reminder of a new life in a new land.
What?	Worship and community law.
How?	The first command relates to worship but also to the place God has given his people, and is a reminder of God's generosity to us and therefore of the need to be generous towards God. The second may be to do with Israel's special purpose, the picture of salvation they are to be in contrast to the practices of other nations – the meaning is unclear. What we can say is that God is very specific about the way in which a calling to be his people works out in practice in the midst of those who do not trust in him.

13.4.4 Leviticus 19:19

"Keep my decrees.
"Do not mate different kinds of animals.
"Do not plant your field with two kinds of seed.
"Do not wear clothing woven of two kinds of material."

Why?	God has rescued them to be a holy people.
Where?	The Holiness Code within Leviticus.
What?	Worship in the broadest sense in Israel – what it means to be holy.
How?	God's presence with his people and God's purpose for his people: there seems to be a picture of holiness here in making distinctions between things. Holiness is to do with separateness. Today the principle is one of being distinct in our lives.

13.4.5 Leviticus 19:27

"Do not cut the hair at the sides of your head or clip off the edges of your beard."

Why?	God has rescued Israel to be a holy people.
Where?	The Holiness Code within Leviticus.
What?	Worship in the broadest sense in Israel – what it means to be holy.
How?	Again to do with Israel's purpose to be distinct from those around them who follow other gods and remain under God's curse. Again the meaning is not clear, but it is probably in the context of the practices of the other nations in the land. Under the New Covenant our inner holiness if of first importance.

Unit 14. Deuteronomy 5:6-21 (Encounter)

This unit applies the lessons of Unit 2 to Deuteronomy 5. Refer back to previous 'Encountering the Bible' units for learning outline and outcomes.

As with previous units that encounter Bible passages, give the participants an opportunity to apply the steps for themselves and help them with the process.

14.1 WORKSHEET FOR THE PASSAGE

6 I am the Lord your God, who brought you out of Egypt, out of the land of slavery.
7 'You shall have no other gods before me.
8 'You shall not make for yourself an image in the form of anything in heaven above or on the earth beneath or in the waters below. 9 You shall not bow down to them or worship them; for I, the Lord your God, am a jealous God, punishing the children for the sin of the parents to the third and fourth generation of those who hate me, 10 but showing love to a thousand generations of those who love me and keep my commandments.
11 'You shall not misuse the name of the Lord your God, for the Lord will not hold anyone guiltless who misuses his name.

12 Observe the Sabbath day by keeping it holy, as the Lord your God has commanded you. 13 Six days you shall labour and do all your work, 14 but the seventh day is a sabbath to the Lord your God. On it you shall not do any work, neither you, nor your son or daughter, nor your male or female servant, nor your ox, your donkey or any of your animals, nor any foreigner residing in your towns, so that your male and female servants may rest, as you do.

15 Remember that you were slaves in Egypt and that the Lord your God brought you out of there with a mighty hand and an outstretched arm. Therefore the Lord your God has commanded you to observe the Sabbath day.

16 Honour your father and your mother, as the Lord your God has commanded you, so that you may live long and that it may go well with you in the land the Lord your God is giving you.

17 ‘You shall not murder.

18 ‘You shall not commit adultery.

19 ‘You shall not steal.

20 ‘You shall not give false testimony against your neighbour.

21 ‘You shall not covet your neighbour’s wife. You shall not set your desire on your neighbour’s house or land, his male or female servant, his ox or donkey, or anything that belongs to your neighbour.’ (NIV)

14.2 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING DEUTERONOMY 5:1-21 – STEP 1

STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text	
a) Set the passage in context. How does the passage relate to the book as a whole?	
b) See the details of the text. List important words, phrases, and relationships:	**c) Seek the meaning from the details** Explain important words, phrases, and relationships:
d) Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?	

14.3 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING DEUT. 5:1-21 – STEPS 2 TO 4

STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text **a) Note all the bones in the structure.** What elements highlight the structure?
b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure. What are the most important parts of the structure? Can you describe the main sections?
STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text **a) State the theme of the passage.** What is the author's main point?
b) Explain the message of the passage. What is the author saying about his theme?
STEP 4: BRAIN – first, understand the PURPOSE of the text... **a) State the purpose of the passage.** Why is the author making his point?
b) Make connections for teaching today. What is the relevance of this for us?

14.4 PREACHING DEUTERONOMY 5:16-21

In order to consider how to preach Exodus 3:1-12 we will, first, respond to the message at a more personal level, picking up on the discoveries we have already made. We will then use the table on the next page to capture some key ideas for a sermon or talk.

14.4.1 Responding to the message of Deuteronomy 5:16-21

Here are three simple exercises to do in response to God's word to us in the passage we have just encountered:

1. Describe how the message you discovered in the passage spoke to you personally: What did you learn or need to be reminded of?

2. Share how the purpose of the passage helped you to apply God's word to your life: What change will this passage make to your thinking and living?

3. State and explain the message you will share with others using your own words: What is the main thing you want people to understand?

14.4.2 Preaching the message of Deuteronomy 5:16-21

Use the table below to outline some of the key ideas in your sermon or talk:

STEP 4: BRAIN – state the PURPOSE of the sermon My sermon's purpose statement:
STEP 5: HEART – form the MESSAGE of the sermon My sermon's theme and its message statement:
STEP 6: SKELETON – create the STRUCTURE of the sermon My sermon's outline (with the main points, introduction and conclusion):
STEP 7: FLESH – develop the DETAILS of the sermon My sermon's details (note here key words, explanations, illustrations and applications that will help you write notes or a full sermon):

Unit 15. Leading by faith (Action)

Overview
The module closes with a practical study of Hebrews 11 that looks back at the promises of God and looks forward in faith.

Outline
- Introduction: The challenge of living and leading by faith
- Living by faith in the promises of God
- Leading by faith in the promises of God

Outcomes
At the end of the unit you will be able to
1. Understand what it means to live by faith
2. Apply lessons of living by faith to leadership
3. Pray with others for everything good for doing God's will

15.1 INTRODUCTION: THE CHALLENGE OF LIVING AND LEADING BY FAITH

There are many times when it is hard for us as Christian leaders to live by faith let alone lead by faith.

- Spend a moment thinking of a past situation in which it has felt almost impossible to trust God. Share that situation with a fellow Christian leader as openly as you can. What were the challenges involved? How did you approach those challenges? Were there Scriptures that spoke to you in that time? Did you feel you were a success or a failure in your response?

15.2 LIVING BY FAITH IN THE PROMISES OF GOD

The Pentateuch has been full of the promises of God: we have seen them in the unfolding plan of salvation; we have seen them in the covenants God makes; we have seen them in Gods' faithfulness in Christ, who fulfils all the promises of the Old Testament. The Pentateuch is also full of men and women who responded to God's promises with faith, and who learnt faith in the midst of the difficulties they faced.

We have also repeatedly looked at the letter to the Hebrews because of the way in which it looks back to the Pentateuch and God's promises and demonstrates how Christ and his gospel, the new covenant, is superior to the old covenant. The old was good, but the

new is better. It was clearly written to Jewish Christians who knew their Old Testament scriptures and who were facing all sorts of pressures and the temptation to give in.

Hebrews 11 looks back to many of the characters we have come across in the Pentateuch and uses them as examples of those who kept going and “were still living by faith when they died”. Hebrews 12:1-3 then uses those examples to encourage us to fix “our eyes on Jesus, the pioneer and perfecter of faith” so that we “will not grow weary and lose heart”.

The characters and stories in Hebrews 11:1-29 are all taken from the Pentateuch, with 11:30 onwards turning to Joshua and other Old Testament examples.

- Consider Hebrews 11:1, “Now faith is confidence in what we hope for and assurance about what we do not see.” And then select a few of the individuals that follow and think about the ways in which they demonstrate that principle of confidence in the promises of God for a better future despite a lack of immediate evidence. You have these individuals to pick from: Abel, Enoch, Noah, Abraham, Sarah, Isaac, Jacob, Joseph and Moses. And the example of God’s people in their passing through the Red Sea as well.

- How do these examples encourage you, in your present situation, to live by faith?

15.3 LEADING BY FAITH IN THE PROMISES OF GOD

15.3.1 The examples of the heroes of faith in the Pentateuch

The characters in Hebrews 11 are leaders of different kinds. Leaders need first to learn to live by faith, to trust God despite the struggles they face in their day to day lives. But they also need to learn to lead by faith. To trust God in the uncertainty of the present as they lead their people into the future.

- What can you learn from Noah, Abraham, Joseph and Moses about leading by faith?

15.3.2 The example of Jesus

Take another look at Hebrews 12:2-3:

> "For the joy that was set before him [Jesus] endured the cross, scorning its shame, and sat down at the right hand of the throne of God. Consider him who endured such opposition from sinners, so that you will not grow weary and lose heart."

- When you consider Jesus, what do you learn about living and leading by faith?

- Finally, commit one another into God's hands with the words of the blessing at the end of the book of Hebrews:

Hebrews 13:20-21:

> "Now may the God of peace, who through the blood of the eternal covenant brought back from the dead our Lord Jesus, that great Shepherd of the sheep, equip you with everything good for doing his will, and may he work in us what is pleasing to him, through Jesus Christ, to whom be glory for ever and ever. Amen."

- You might want to ask specifically for God's equipping for things you and others are facing in your lives and ministries.

Review questions for Module Two

- Look back through the titles of the units in the module. Can you recall which units had the greatest impact on you and why?

- Look back at the module and reflect on the question of whether and how your leadership has changed as a result of the teaching in the module.

- In a similar way, reflect on the ways in which your church has been influenced by any teaching from the module that you have passed on in some way.

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